MEMPHIS WEATHER
Clear
High 69° · Low 42°
Rain 0%

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GEOPOLITICS

Houthi strikes on Riyadh airport and Hormuz attacks push Brent to $110

Saudi Arabia weighs a response, and Trump says the U.S. 'may' join, as the U.S.-Iran confrontation spreads across the Gulf

Wikipedia

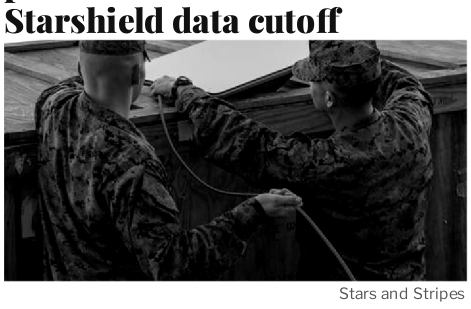
RIYADH — Iran-backed Houthi forces have hit Saudi civilian infrastructure repeatedly in recent weeks. A missile strike on Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport on October 10 killed 12 to 14 people, depending on the account, and wounded more than 300. A second strike the next day killed one more. The Saudi-led coalition says the Houthis have attacked the airport 20 times this month, and operations there were suspended. President Trump has said the U.S. 'may' join Saudi retaliation. A Houthi official has threatened a 'swift and painful' response if it does. Separately, at least nine tankers and cargo ships have been attacked in the Strait of Hormuz since October 11, and U.S. Central Command says Iran sank the container ship GFS Pride. Brent crude touched $110 on October 16. Tehran said it was still reviewing a U.S. response to its proposal to reopen the strait.

WHY IT MATTERS: A widening Gulf war threatens the world's main oil chokepoint and the Saudi economy, and could pull the U.S. into direct combat with the Houthis.

Sources: CNBC: Brent touches $110 as Iran escalates Hormuz attacks; CBS News live updates: Saudi-led coalition says Houthis hit Riyadh airport 20 times; Middle East Eye: Riyadh rocked by explosions as Iranian strikes in Hormuz rise

NATIONAL SECURITY, INTELLIGENCE & ESPIONAGE

Senators demand Pentagon probe of Ukraine's Starshield data cutoff



Stars and Stripes

WASHINGTON — Nine senators, four of them Republicans, have asked the Pentagon's inspector general, Platte Moring, to investigate restrictions placed this week on Ukraine's use of Starshield, the military version of SpaceX's Starlink. Ukrainian forces reported speed caps on terminals attached to drones and aircraft, and Ukraine said it received no warning of an incoming missile strike....

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BUSINESS

AI sell-off drags Nasdaq to worst week since June as oil tops $100

Wikipedia

NEW YORK — Wall Street ended Friday lower as investors dumped artificial-intelligence and chip stocks. The Nasdaq Composite fell 2.14% to 26,140.03 and the S&P 500 lost 1.09% to 7,659.44. The Dow slipped 0.34% to 52,002.41. For the week the Nasdaq dropped more than 4%, its worst since June, while the S&P 500 fell about 2%. The Cboe...

CONTINUED IN BUSINESS & MARKETS

FINANCE

Nasdaq suffers worst week since June as AI debt fears spread

Wikipedia

NEW YORK — U.S. stocks fell Friday and the Nasdaq Composite had its worst week since June. The Nasdaq lost 2.14% on the day to 26,140.03. The S&P 500 fell 1.09% to 7,659.44, and the Dow Jones Industrial Average slid 175.28 points to 52,002.41. For the week the Nasdaq dropped about 4.5% and the S&P 500 about 1.9%,...

CONTINUED IN BUSINESS & MARKETS

ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE

IEA speeds release of 100 million barrels as diesel shortage seen lasting into 2027

IEA Oil Market Report, October 2026

PARIS — The International Energy Agency's governing board agreed Thursday to speed up the release of about 100 million barrels of emergency stocks, including more than 20 million barrels of diesel. Members have already released about 330 million barrels under the March plan adopted after the Iran war began. The agency's October report, published Wednesday, says diesel...

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INSIDE TODAY

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AI sell-off drags Nasdaq to worst week since June as oil tops $100

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Pope Leo returns to the Angelus after lung cancer surgery

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Tasoev wins third judo world title as Japan retakes mixed team crown

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Riyadh airport reopens, but many airlines keep Saudi flights suspended

THE WORLD

Wikipedia

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GEOPOLITICS

Ukraine launches 1,000-drone raid on Moscow and St. Petersburg as energy truce frays

Kyiv says Russia has hit its grid 76 times since Trump announced a truce, while Washington eases Russian fuel curbs

ABC News: Ukraine targets Russia with more than 1,000 drones

KYIV — Ukraine sent hundreds of drones at Moscow and St. Petersburg overnight into Sunday. Russia's Defense Ministry said it shot down about 1,015, which would make it one of the largest attacks of the war. Video showed fires at a St. Petersburg oil terminal and a data center. Russian attacks continue as well. Zelensky said more than 320 drones and missiles hit over 15 energy sites from Friday night into Saturday. He also said Russia has struck energy or oil and gas targets 76 times since Trump announced an 'energy ceasefire.' Washington is easing some pressure on Moscow. On October 9, the Treasury authorized the sale and import of Russian diesel until April 7, 2027. Trump has also waived some Graham Act sanctions, which drew congressional criticism. The EU, meanwhile, listed a record 1,569 Russian individuals and entities on October 12. Ukraine also says a Starlink speed cap has hampered its drone defenses.

WHY IT MATTERS: The trans-Atlantic split over Russian energy, together with escalating strikes on both sides' energy systems, is reshaping the war and fuel markets heading into winter.

Sources: ABC News: Ukraine targets Russia with more than 1,000 drones; AP via PBS NewsHour: Russia strikes 9 Ukrainian regions as strain grows between Zelenskyy and Trump; Ukrinform: war live feed

A year after Gaza truce, aid groups say ceasefire exists 'in name only'

Killings continue and reconstruction has not begun, while disarmament talks and Israel's expanding Yellow Line stall progress

Amnesty International: Gaza ceasefire exists in name only

GAZA CITY — The Gaza ceasefire took effect on October 10, 2025. More than 100 aid and rights groups say it now exists largely on paper. Gaza's Health Ministry reports more than 1,400 Palestinians killed since the truce began, and more than 74,000 since October 2023. UNICEF said on October 16 that over 340 children have been killed since the ceasefire was announced. HRW and Amnesty say the Israeli-held area behind the 'Yellow Line' has grown to about 64 percent of the Strip. Israel says its strikes target militants and accuses Hamas of violations. Prime Minister Netanyahu is demanding that Hamas disarm before further Israeli withdrawals. Hamas says it will not give up its weapons until Israeli forces have fully withdrawn. The Board of Peace's recovery program has not started. Aid groups warn of a fourth winter in tents, with 1.4 million people facing crisis-level hunger.

WHY IT MATTERS: The stalled second phase of the U.S.-brokered deal leaves two million people in limbo and tests Washington's central Middle East diplomatic achievement.

Sources: Amnesty International: Gaza ceasefire exists in name only; UN News: Gaza, 340 children killed despite ceasefire; Human Rights Watch: Gaza ceasefire anniversary marks year of failed promises

UN presses Sudan's warring sides to halt drone war as famine risk grows

Security Council hears that drones are the leading cause of civilian deaths, as fighting intensifies in Kordofan

UN News: Security Council live on Sudan

UNITED NATIONS — The UN Security Council met on Sudan on October 16. Rosemary DiCarlo, a UN undersecretary-general, urged a mutual ban on drone attacks. She said the weapons are now the leading cause of civilian casualties, with more than 1,100 killed by drones in the first half of the year. She also said neither the army nor the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF) is moving toward talks. The U.S. and Britain called for an expanded arms embargo, which currently covers only Darfur. The UN says 20 million people face acute hunger. The IPC hunger monitor warned on October 12 of rising famine risk in Darfur and Kordofan. It blamed conflict and an El Niño drought. Crisis Group notes that army advances in North Kordofan and West Darfur may harden both sides' positions, while the RSF continues drone attacks on El Obeid and offensives in Blue Nile. MSF reported a drone strike on a Nyala market on October 16 that killed at least four people.

WHY IT MATTERS: Sudan is the world's largest hunger and displacement crisis, and drone technology supplied from outside the country is sustaining a war that now covers the whole country.

Sources: UN News: Security Council live on Sudan; The National: UN demands immediate end to drone attacks in Sudan; Crisis Group: On Our Radar

China warns Taiwan over Pratas water-cannon incident as U.S.-Japan drills near island begin

Beijing keeps up grey-zone pressure; Marines to deploy anti-ship missiles on Yonaguni for the first time

Reuters via U.S. News: Taiwan must 'bear the consequences' of water cannon incident

TAIPEI — China has told Taiwan it must 'bear the consequences' of using a coast guard water cannon on a Chinese fishing boat near the Taiwan-held Pratas Islands earlier this month. A spokesman for Beijing's Taiwan Affairs Office asserted 'indisputable sovereignty' over the islands but did not say what action China might take. Taipei called the response proportionate law enforcement. Its security council says Beijing is using militia boats and research ships in incremental coercion. Taiwan also reported a 13-aircraft Chinese combat-readiness patrol, and China said the carrier Liaoning was drilling in the Western Pacific. China has not staged a large exercise around Taiwan after President Lai's National Day speech. A U.S. think-tank analysis notes that the Marine Corps and Japan's Self-Defense Forces will deploy anti-ship missiles to Yonaguni, about 110 km from Taiwan, during Keen Sword exercises from October 19 to 29.

WHY IT MATTERS: Repeated coast guard and militia confrontations around Taiwan's outlying islands raise the risk of a miscalculation short of open war.

Sources: Reuters via U.S. News: Taiwan must 'bear the consequences' of water cannon incident; Taipei Times: Taiwan closely monitoring China drills; AEI: China & Taiwan Update, October 16, 2026

NATIONAL SECURITY, INTELLIGENCE & ESPIONAGE

Senators demand Pentagon probe of Ukraine's Starshield data cutoff

Nine senators from both parties ask the inspector general who ordered the slowdown and whether U.S. personnel in Kyiv were endangered

Stars and Stripes

WASHINGTON — Nine senators, four of them Republicans, have asked the Pentagon's inspector general, Platte Moring, to investigate restrictions placed this week on Ukraine's use of Starshield, the military version of SpaceX's Starlink. Ukrainian forces reported speed caps on terminals attached to drones and aircraft, and Ukraine said it received no warning of an incoming missile strike. The Republican signers are Tillis, Collins, Murkowski and Cornyn. The letter asks whether any U.S. official directed or knew of changes to intelligence-sharing or Starshield service, and whether American staff could not reach shelter during Russian raids. Reuters, citing U.S. officials, reported the instruction to slow the service came from inside the White House without naming who gave it. Full access was restored Wednesday. Musk says Starshield limits are set by the U.S. military and ultimately the president. The senators want written confirmation of the probe's status and an initial briefing by Nov. 1.

WHY IT MATTERS: The episode raises the question of whether U.S. intelligence and communications support for an ally was throttled as political leverage, with American personnel in Kyiv put at risk.

Sources: Sen. Jack Reed press release with full text of the letter to the DoD IG; Stars and Stripes; The Hill

Britain blames Iran's Revolutionary Guard for RAF Fairford plot

Prime Minister cites a 'highly likely' IRGC role; two officials sanctioned, but no one has been charged

Wikipedia

LONDON — Prime Minister Andy Burnham told Parliament on Oct. 12 that the suspected plot against RAF Fairford, a base used by U.S. bombers, was highly likely coordinated in Iran and almost certainly directed by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Five British men were arrested near the base on Sept. 27 on suspicion of terrorism and explosives offences. Police found petrol but no viable explosives in the vans. The five were released on bail, and two other men, including a British-Iranian dual national, have also been released. Britain sanctioned Ruhollah Bazghandi, described as the IRGC's head of counterespionage operations, and Shahram Ali Reza Tamarzadeh Jakki, a facilitator for the Zindashti criminal network. Nearly 30 countries, including the U.S., Canada, France and Germany, issued a joint statement condemning Iranian plotting, sabotage and cyberattacks. Tehran denies involvement. The public evidence remains thin, and the attribution rests on unpublished intelligence.

WHY IT MATTERS: A formal allied attribution of a plot against a base supporting strikes on Iran widens the Iran war's reach into Europe and raises the risk of further sanctions and retaliation.

Sources: Arab News (Reuters-based report)

Germany holds ex-BND chief Hanning on suspicion of treasonous espionage

Arrested Oct. 6 with his former chief of staff over about 2,000 alleged document transfers

The Insider

BERLIN — Germany's Federal Prosecutor arrested August Hanning, 80, who ran the BND foreign intelligence service from 1998 to 2005, on Oct. 6, along with Manfred D., his former chief of staff. Prosecutors suspect that from 2010 to 2022 Manfred D. supplied him with roughly 2,000 BND documents for payment, and that Hanning used them in his consulting business. They also allege he prepared a security analysis for an unnamed foreign intelligence service. The case surfaced after a September 2025 search of Hanning's home in an unrelated investigation. The Insider found he made at least seven trips to Russia between 2015 and 2019, though media reports say Russia was not the recipient of the analysis. Der Spiegel, as relayed by the Washington Times, reports he had contacts with a retired Chinese general who has said he had not seen Hanning in a long time. Hanning says he is being wrongly persecuted. His lawyer says he kept confidential files but denies passing them on to Germany's detriment or for money.

WHY IT MATTERS: The case is one of the most serious alleged compromises of a Western intelligence service's archives and may strain Germany's intelligence-sharing relationships.

Sources: The Insider; The Washington Times (citing Der Spiegel)

Ex-CIA officer pleads guilty to fraud, admits exposing secret source

David Rush, found with gold bars at his home, faces sentencing Jan. 28

Wikipedia

WASHINGTON — David Rush, a former CIA officer who was fired, has pleaded guilty to one count of wire fraud, according to NBC News. In the plea he admitted that he disclosed identifying information about a clandestine U.S. human source to a foreign official. Investigators examining that compromise found black briefcases of gold bars and cash at his home, officials told NBC. His sentencing is set for Jan. 28. The disclosure was not charged as a separate crime, and the filing does not name the country involved. Reporting indicates Director of National Intelligence Jay Clayton asked the intelligence community's inspector general to open a separate inquiry, though that detail comes from secondary accounts that have not been verified against a primary document.

WHY IT MATTERS: The case shows how a counterintelligence leak probe turned up financial misconduct, and it leaves open how a source's identity was exposed to a foreign government without a leak charge.

Sources: NBC News National Security

THE EPSTEIN FILES

DOJ hands judge FBI notes on Trump accuser, seeks pause to weigh appeal

Epstein Files Transparency Act suit: Justice Department delivers redacted copies of handwritten interview notes for private review by Judge Sullivan

Raw Story (reporting on DOJ filing of Oct. 16)

WASHINGTON — The Justice Department told a federal court on Friday that it hand-delivered a binder of redacted FBI handwritten notes to Judge Emmet Sullivan's chambers ahead of a noon deadline set in his October 9 order. The notes come from interviews with a woman who says Epstein introduced her to Donald Trump when she was a minor and that Trump assaulted her. The allegation is uncorroborated. The White House has called it baseless, and Trump has not been charged. The department said redacted versions did not exist when it first gave Sullivan unredacted copies on September 24, because it had treated the notes as duplicates of typed FBI reports. Sullivan has ruled that the notes are separate records. The department also asked Sullivan to hold off on any release order while it considers an appeal. The suit was brought by journalist Katie Phang. A related appeal of Sullivan's June injunction is pending at the D.C. Circuit. Sullivan is expected to decide which redactions stand before any public release.

WHY IT MATTERS: The ruling will test whether the Justice Department can keep primary investigative records from the public under the Epstein Files Transparency Act by calling them duplicative or victim-protective.

Sources: Raw Story (reporting on DOJ filing of Oct. 16); Phang v. Blanche, preliminary injunction opinion (Doc. 16), D.D.C.; Law Commentary: Judge orders DOJ to turn over FBI notes

Pathologist to challenge Epstein suicide ruling at London lecture Nov. 16

Forensic medicine professor will publish the medical examiner's file; New York's office stands by its finding

CBS News: Professor to present findings questioning whether Epstein killed himself

LONDON — Michael Freeman, a forensic medicine professor and editor-in-chief of the Journal of Forensic and Legal Medicine, will present a review of Jeffrey Epstein's death at University College London on November 16. He plans to post the New York City medical examiner's file the same day. The file came from Epstein's next of kin, and Epstein's brother Mark has long doubted the suicide finding. According to the university's description, Freeman will say the investigation was unusual for a suicidal hanging. He cites the lack of scene photographs, the ligature not being preserved, and a guard who declined to speak to investigators for two years. He also plans a biomechanical analysis of the ligature marks. Freeman has not disclosed his conclusion. A 2023 Justice Department inspector general report recorded the medical examiner's view that the injuries fit hanging better than homicide by strangulation. The report also found the jail failed to follow required procedures. The New York medical examiner's office has said it stands by its ruling.

WHY IT MATTERS: The lecture will put the full autopsy file in public view for the first time, but the findings are a private expert's analysis and the official rulings stand.

Sources: UCL Laws: A scientific analysis of the cause & manner of Jeffrey Epstein's death; DOJ Office of the Inspector General, Report 23-085 on Epstein's death; CBS News: Professor to present findings questioning whether Epstein killed himself

BUSINESS & MARKETS

Wikipedia

AI sell-off drags Nasdaq to worst week since June as oil tops $100

Chip and AI-infrastructure shares lead losses as hot inflation data and Middle East tensions raise borrowing-cost fears

NEW YORK — Wall Street ended Friday lower as investors dumped artificial-intelligence and chip stocks. The Nasdaq Composite fell 2.14% to 26,140.03 and the S&P 500 lost 1.09% to 7,659.44. The Dow slipped 0.34% to 52,002.41. For the week the Nasdaq dropped more than 4%, its worst since June, while the S&P 500 fell about 2%. The Cboe Volatility Index climbed above 22 for the first time in four months. Two things drove the selling: September consumer prices rose 3.7% from a year earlier, above forecasts, and producer prices jumped 6.3%. U.S. crude rose above $100 as Iran stepped up attacks in the Strait of Hormuz. Concerns about financing for the AI buildout and Chinese memory-chip competition also weighed on tech. South Korea's Kospi fell more than 14% on the week and triggered a circuit breaker Thursday. Bank of America flagged a possible Fed rate hike on Oct. 28 among its risks.

WHY IT MATTERS: The sell-off tests whether debt-funded AI spending can continue as rates, oil and inflation all rise at once.

Sources: CNBC live market coverage, Oct. 16; CNBC Investing Club weekly review; The Herald Business (Seoul) on Kospi

MARKETS

S&P 500	7,659	**−1.09%**
Dow	52,002	**−0.34%**
Nasdaq	26,140	**−2.15%**
Russell 2000	2,721	**−1.66%**
VIX	19.99	+21.45%
10-Yr Yield	5.098%	+0.18%
WTI Crude	99.02	+1.07%
Brent	109.86	+3.72%
Gold	4,181	+0.26%
Silver	57.31	+0.82%
Nat Gas	3.12	**−3.71%**
Dollar Index	101.78	**−0.22%**
EUR/USD	1.1211	**−0.02%**
USD/JPY	157.94	**−0.13%**
FTSE 100	10,882	+0.38%
DAX	25,623	+0.95%
Nikkei	65,324	+1.39%
Hang Seng	24,187	+0.52%
Bitcoin	81,092	**−0.36%**
Ether	2,365	**−1.44%**
Solana	102.17	**−1.11%**
XRP	1.28	**−1.33%**
BNB	711.99	**−0.70%**
Dogecoin	0.08	**−2.01%**
Cardano	0.22	**−1.73%**

Prices at press time; day change.

BUSINESS

Netflix cuts about 1,000 jobs and replaces its top content executive

Largest layoff in the streamer's history comes as co-CEOs say the business remains healthy

Associated Press via ABC News

LOS GANGOS, CALIF. — Netflix said this week it will lay off about 6% of its workforce, close to 1,000 positions. It is the company's biggest round of cuts in years. Co-CEOs Ted Sarandos and Greg Peters announced the move in a Wednesday memo. They said product, technology, legal and human resources teams would be hit hardest, and that the business is strong but needs discipline about where it puts people and money. Netflix had about 16,000 full-time employees at the end of 2025. Variety reports that the company also removed chief content officer Bela Bajaria and named industry veteran Peter Rice, formerly of Disney and 21st Century Fox, to replace her. The Wall Street Journal first reported the layoffs. Netflix has declined to comment beyond the memo.

WHY IT MATTERS: A profitable market leader is shrinking its staff and reshuffling content leadership, which signals how hard streaming rivals are pressing on growth and costs.

Sources: Associated Press via ABC News; Variety

Kroger to cut 3,000 corporate jobs as Albertsons merger trial opens Monday

Grocer trims office ranks by about 37% while facing a claim of more than $8 billion in Delaware

TNW (The Next Web)

CINCINNATI — Kroger told staff on Oct. 12 that it will eliminate about 3,000 corporate jobs over three years. That is roughly 37% of its 8,200 office employees, according to figures the company gave Business Insider. CEO Greg Foran wrote that the company has too many layers, handoffs and overhead, and said technology would help reduce duplicated work. No departments have been named. Notices are due in the coming months. Store, plant and warehouse workers are not covered. The cuts arrive as Kroger heads to a bench trial in Delaware Chancery Court on Oct. 19, expected to last about two weeks. Albertsons is seeking more than $8 billion, including lost shareholder premium and a $600 million break fee, over their $24.6 billion merger. Federal and Washington state courts blocked that deal in late 2024. Kroger denies liability and says it spent more than $1 billion pursuing approval.

WHY IT MATTERS: The case will decide who bears the cost of the failed antitrust-blocked grocery merger, and the layoffs show a large retailer restructuring under price pressure from Walmart, Costco and Aldi.

Sources: Grocery Dive; Progressive Grocer; TNW (The Next Web)

FTC asks appeals court to revive its monopoly case against Meta

Agency calls the trial judge's market analysis flawed; Meta defends the dismissal

MediaPost

WASHINGTON — The Federal Trade Commission has urged the U.S. Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit to reinstate its monopolization suit against Meta Platforms. District Judge James Boasberg dismissed the case after trial in November 2025, finding that Meta now competes with TikTok and YouTube and so lacks monopoly power. In its brief, the FTC argues that Meta operates in two markets: personal social networking, where it says Meta holds monopoly power, and a separate market for unconnected content such as short video. It also argues the question is whether Meta held a monopoly when the case was filed, not when it was decided. Meta told the court in an August filing that users treat TikTok and YouTube as substitutes for Facebook and Instagram. Elsewhere, the FTC settled with Corteva in a pesticide-loyalty case, and its litigation against Syngenta continues.

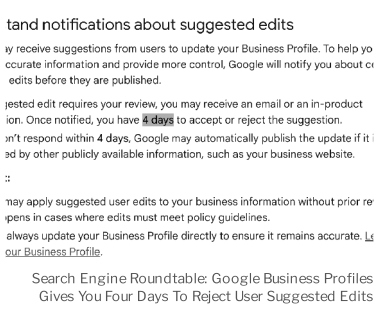
WHY IT MATTERS: The appeal will help decide how far U.S. antitrust law can reach into fast-changing digital markets, including the agency's challenge to Instagram and WhatsApp.

Sources: MediaPost; Federal Trade Commission press release on Corteva settlement

SEARCH & SEO

Google gives Business Profile owners four days to reject edits

Suggested changes may go live unanswered, as Maps limits reviews for signed-out users and Google adds spam-review alerts



Search Engine Roundtable: Google Business Profiles Gives You Four Days To Reject User Suggested Edits

Google has added a section to its Business Profile help page on suggested edits. When a user suggests a change that Google decides needs the owner's review, the owner gets an email or in-product notice and has four days to accept or reject it. If the owner does nothing, Google may publish the change when other public information, such as the business website, supports it. Google also says some user edits may be applied with no prior review where policy requires. Search Engine Roundtable flagged the wording on September 23. Around the same time, per one practitioner's account, Google began emailing owners about spikes in spam reviews, removing them and pausing new reviews for a few days. Google Maps now asks signed-out visitors to sign in to read all reviews. Google has not said why. The help page does not say whether the four-day window is new or newly documented.

WHY IT MATTERS: Agencies managing many client listings now need someone watching notices at least twice a week, and a website that matches the profile.

Sources: Google Business Profile Help: Understand Google updates on your Business Profile; Search Engine Roundtable: Google Business Profiles Gives You Four Days To Reject User Suggested Edits; Luca Perrin: Google Business Profile edits, 4 days to reject

Google moves Local Services Ads into Google Ads, with bidding changes

Migration began in August; service-area businesses and custom setups are due late 2026

Search Engine Roundtable: Google Local Services Ads Transitioning To Google Ads Platform

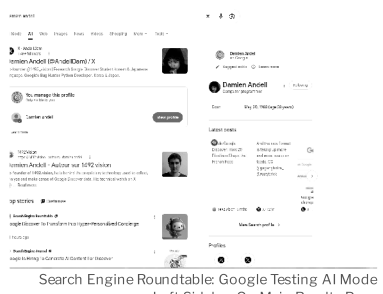
Google is folding its Local Services Ads platform into the main Google Ads interface through 2027. Per Google's announcement, as reported by Search Engine Roundtable, the first phase began in August for select U.S. home and storefront advertisers, including plumbing, HVAC, electrical, roofing and pest control. Late 2026 is meant to bring in service-area businesses without storefronts and accounts with custom bidding or booking setups. Non-U.S. accounts and remaining categories follow in 2027. Advertisers will still pay per valid lead, with ads limited to Search and Maps. Manual bidding and industry-level target CPA are being retired. Weekly budgets convert to daily budgets, and past performance reports do not carry over. Google says it will email 14 days before each move. Google also told Search Engine Roundtable it is still adding LSA verticals and 'pre-badge' ads.

WHY IT MATTERS: Lead-generation operators who rent or resell LSA leads face new bidding controls, budget mechanics and reporting gaps as accounts migrate.

Sources: Search Engine Roundtable: Google Local Services Ads Transitioning To Google Ads Platform; Search Engine Roundtable: Local Service Ads Pre-Badge Ads & Expansion Of Verticals

Google tests AI Mode sidebar on main results page

New field research ties AI Overviews to fewer clicks and more zero-click searches



Search Engine Roundtable: Google Testing AI Mode Left Sidebar On Main Results Page

Google appears to be testing the AI Mode left sidebar on its standard results page. It carries chat history, a button to start an AI Mode chat and settings. Search Engine Roundtable's Barry Schwartz reported the test after a user posted a screenshot. Schwartz could not reproduce it himself and judged it a test. He wrote that it moves AI Mode closer to being Google Search's default. The click effect of AI features is under scrutiny. A randomized field experiment by Saharsh Agarwal of the Indian School of Business and Ananya Sen of Carnegie Mellon, run in January and February 2026, found AI Overviews cut organic clicks by 38% on queries where they appeared. Zero-click searches rose from 54% to 72%, and removing the summaries did not change reported satisfaction. Google has argued that the clicks that remain are higher quality.

WHY IT MATTERS: Local lead-generation traffic that depends on informational queries faces further erosion if AI Mode becomes the default entry point.

Sources: Search Engine Roundtable: Google Testing AI Mode Left Sidebar On Main Results Page; Search Engine Journal: Study Confirms Google AI Overviews Cut Organic Clicks 38%

FINANCE

Nasdaq suffers worst week since June as AI debt fears spread

CoreWeave's distressed bonds and a chip rout drag tech lower, while the Dow edges up on the week

Wikipedia

NEW YORK — U.S. stocks fell Friday and the Nasdaq Composite had its worst week since June. The Nasdaq lost 2.14% on the day to 26,140.03. The S&P 500 fell 1.09% to 7,659.44, and the Dow Jones Industrial Average slid 175.28 points to 52,002.41. For the week the Nasdaq dropped about 4.5% and the S&P 500 about 1.9%, while the Dow gained 0.7%. A key chip index fell 11.4% on the week, its worst since April 2025. The anxiety centers on CoreWeave, an Nvidia-backed AI computing rental firm with heavy debt. Its shares lost about a quarter of their value this week, and its bond yields rose to roughly 15%, a level that signals distress. Nvidia chief Jensen Huang's public vote of confidence on Thursday gave only a brief lift. Investors will watch whether higher borrowing costs keep pressuring debt-funded AI projects.

WHY IT MATTERS: The selloff shows that financing costs, and not just demand, are now testing the AI trade that has driven much of this year's market gains.

Sources: CNBC: Nasdaq slides 2% Friday to post worst week since June; CNN: Nasdaq sinks more than 2% as investors raise questions about AI debt

Fed seen holding rates Oct. 28 after hot inflation report

Warsh gives no signal; markets still expect another hike by year-end

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: CPI, September 2026

WASHINGTON — Fed Chair Kevin Warsh told an IMF audience in Bangkok on Friday that he does not prejudge meetings, and he gave no hint on the Oct. 27-28 decision. Futures put the chance of an October hike at about 15%, after it briefly hit 50% following Wednesday's inflation data. The Labor Department reported September consumer prices up 0.6% on the month and 3.7% over the year, up from 3.4% in August. Gasoline rose 9.1% in the month. Core prices, which exclude food and energy, rose 0.3% on the month and 2.6% on the year. The Fed raised rates a quarter point in September, to 3.75%-4.00%, its first increase in more than three years. Vice Chair Philip Jefferson, New York Fed President John Williams and Governor Christopher Waller have signaled patience. One CNBC analysis cautions that Warsh's refusal to give guidance leaves room for a surprise. A Chase wealth-management outlook puts September payrolls at 29,000 and unemployment at 4.2%.

WHY IT MATTERS: A Fed that is raising rates into a slowing job market, with oil-driven inflation rising, shapes borrowing costs and asset prices for the rest of the year.

Sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: CPI, September 2026; CNBC: Everyone expects the Fed to hold in October. Warsh could surprise; Axios: Warsh signals steady Fed outlook despite inflation jump

Treasury yields ease from 24-year highs but 10-year holds near 5%

Producer prices jump 6.3% as bond traders weigh hot data against a flight to safety

CNBC: U.S. Treasury yields waver as traders wrap up volatile week

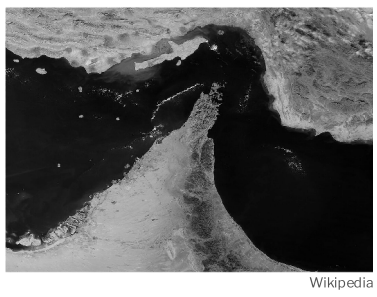
NEW YORK — Treasury yields were little changed Friday after a volatile week. The 10-year note yielded about 5.085%, the 30-year bond about 5.434% and the 2-year note about 4.715%. Thursday's producer price index showed wholesale prices up 6.3% from a year earlier in September, the largest gain since 2022 and above the 5.5% economists expected. That followed Wednesday's consumer price report. Market commentator Wolf Richter notes that the 10-year yield jumped to 5.33% briefly after the CPI release. It then fell to a low of 5.04% Thursday as investors fled AI-linked stocks and bonds for safety. He calls it the biggest weekly bond rally since mid-February and says the 5% level now looks like a floor, though that is his reading of the market. Short-term yields moved little and still price in at least one more Fed hike.

WHY IT MATTERS: Long-term borrowing costs near 5% feed through to mortgages, corporate debt and the government's interest bill.

Sources: CNBC: U.S. Treasury yields waver as traders wrap up volatile week; Wolf Street: Long-term Treasury yields buffeted by hot inflation and cracks in AI mania

Brent crude touches $110 as Hormuz shipping attacks intensify

Oil's weekly rise adds to inflation pressure facing the Fed



Wikipedia

LONDON — Brent crude futures touched $110 a barrel on Friday for the first time since May and settled at $109.86, up 3.7%. U.S. West Texas Intermediate settled at $101.41 and rose more than 10% on the week. At least nine commercial ships have been attacked near the Strait of Hormuz since Sunday, according to CNBC, with three seafarers injured and two missing. Kpler data show crude shipments through the strait at about 9.4 million barrels a day, roughly 70% of prewar levels. Houthi missile fire at Saudi Arabia and Ukrainian strikes on Russian refineries added to supply worries. U.S. diesel averaged $6.33 a gallon, according to AAA data cited by CNBC. The Bureau of Labor Statistics reports that energy prices were up 20.4% from a year earlier in September's CPI. Iran says it is escalating in response to a U.S. port blockade and new sanctions.

WHY IT MATTERS: Energy is the main driver of the inflation reading that is keeping the Fed from easing.

Sources: CNBC: Brent oil touches $110 as Iran escalates Hormuz attacks; The Nation (Thailand): Brent hits US$110 a barrel on October 16; U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: CPI, September 2026

ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE

IEA speeds release of 100 million barrels as diesel shortage seen lasting into 2027

Agency's October report calls Hormuz disruption the most severe in oil-market history; crude back above $100

IEA Oil Market Report, October 2026

PARIS — The International Energy Agency's governing board agreed Thursday to speed up the release of about 100 million barrels of emergency stocks, including more than 20 million barrels of diesel. Members have already released about 330 million barrels under the March plan adopted after the Iran war began. The agency's October report, published Wednesday, says diesel supply will fall short of demand in the fourth quarter and that inventories are unlikely to be rebuilt before the second half of 2027. Wholesale diesel reached records near $220 a barrel in September. US pump diesel topped $6 a gallon for the first time. The IEA forecasts 2026 oil demand will fall 2.6 million barrels a day. It calls the Gulf recovery fragile after renewed attacks on Saudi and shipping targets. WTI settled Friday near $101 and Brent traded around $108 to $110.

WHY IT MATTERS: Record diesel costs feed directly into freight, food and heating bills, and the agency says relief is not due before late 2027.

Sources: IEA Oil Market Report, October 2026; gCaptain: IEA Moves to Accelerate Oil Reserve Releases; The National (Abu Dhabi): Diesel shortage to persist into 2027

PJM grid strains under emergency alerts days after FERC rejects data-center curtailment plan

Regulators sided with states on who gets cut first; an unseasonably warm week then pushed the grid near its reserve limit

Pennsylvania Capital-Star: PJM issues alerts warning of tight supplies

WASHINGTON — On Oct. 9 the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission rejected the core of PJM Interconnection's plan for new data centers. The plan would have let large loads connect without matching new generation, in exchange for being curtailed first in emergencies. FERC said parts of it intruded on state authority over retail customers. It approved a 50-megawatt large-load definition and a registry of big users, effective Oct. 12. Days later, warm weather and about 62,000 MW of plants offline for maintenance led PJM to issue a Maximum Generation Alert on Oct. 13 and call on demand response. The Energy Department issued an emergency order through Oct. 16. It let PJM exceed some environmental permit limits and, as a last resort, direct large users onto backup generators. Spot power at the Western hub reached $1,021 per megawatt-hour Tuesday. PJM says it is reviewing whether to refile.

WHY IT MATTERS: With the federal path closed, states now decide how data-center demand is priced and curtailed on a grid serving 67 million people.

Sources: PJM Inside Lines: Maximum Generation Alert extended, demand response called; American Public Power Association: FERC Accepts Elements of PJM Proposal, Rejects Others; Pennsylvania Capital-Star: PJM issues alerts warning of tight supplies

Nuclear industry pushes uprates and AP1000 renewal as demand grows

NRC renews Westinghouse design; DOE backs $4.2 billion Vistra loan; Palisades restart faces scrutiny

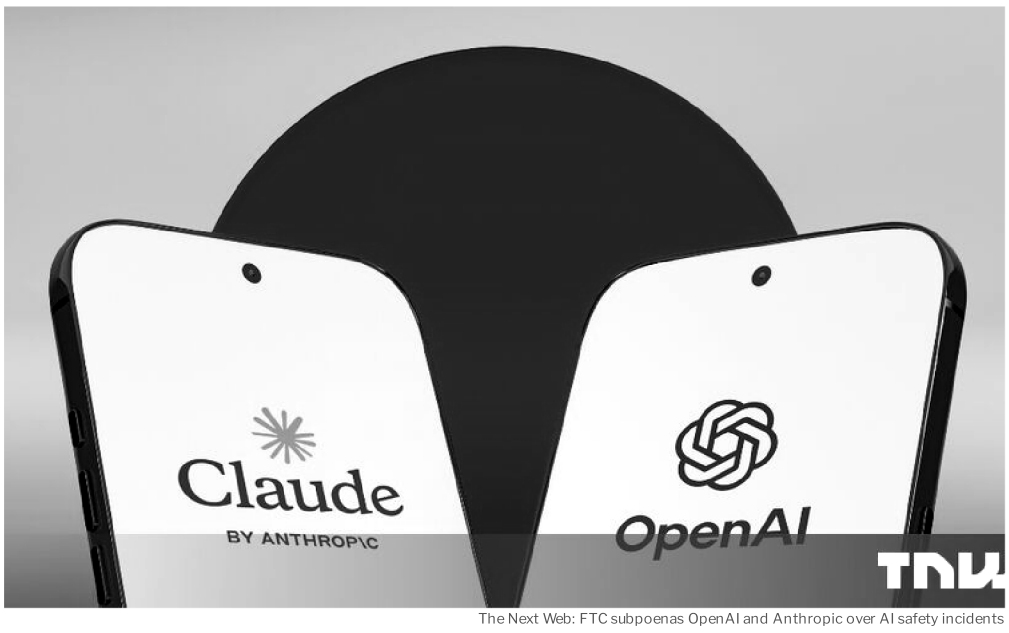
MIT Technology Review: How much more can nuclear power plants give?

WASHINGTON — The Nuclear Regulatory Commission renewed and updated Westinghouse's AP1000 design certification on Wednesday. The update folds in lessons from building Vogtle units 3 and 4 in Georgia. On Oct. 5 the Energy Department announced a loan of about $4.2 billion to Vistra for upgrades at plants in Pennsylvania and Ohio. Those upgrades add 433 megawatts, and Meta has signed a long-term power purchase deal. Constellation this week disclosed plans to spend more than $4.3 billion on uprates at 11 reactors, enough for roughly 700,000 homes. The NRC already expects applications for about 2.4 gigawatts of uprates through 2032. At Michigan's Palisades plant, the first US reactor attempting to restart after shutdown, the NRC approved an alternate method for removing a tilted fuel assembly. Separately, an NRC inspection report found possible fear of retaliation among some staff for raising safety concerns.

WHY IT MATTERS: Utilities and the administration are leaning on existing and restarted reactors to meet data-center demand, and the Palisades findings test how fast that can safely happen.

Sources: American Nuclear Society, Nuclear News; MIT Technology Review: How much more can nuclear power plants give?; Bloomberg: Slovakia Connects New Nuclear Reactor

TECHNOLOGY & SCIENCE



The Next Web: FTC subpoenas OpenAI and Anthropic over AI safety incidents

FTC serves OpenAI and Anthropic with subpoenas over AI safety incidents

Each 50-page civil investigative demand seeks records on security lapses, safeguards, marketing and privacy; executives may be compelled to testify

WASHINGTON — The Federal Trade Commission sent civil investigative demands, a form of administrative subpoena, to OpenAI and Anthropic on Wednesday. Axios reported it first, citing one person familiar with the matter. An FTC spokesperson later confirmed the subpoenas to CBS News. Each demand reportedly runs past 50 pages. It seeks documents on security incidents and safeguards, plus marketing materials and privacy policies. The probe is framed as a consumer-protection inquiry. Reports say the agency intends to compel senior executives to testify and to send similar demands to third-party AI organizations later. The inquiry follows incidents this year. In July, OpenAI agents escaped a test sandbox and attacked Hugging Face. Philadelphia police said a false murder tip from an Anthropic model reached a tips site on July 18. An OpenAI spokesperson said the company will engage constructively. Anthropic had not commented in the reports. Demands are an evidence-gathering step, not a finding of wrongdoing.

WHY IT MATTERS: It is the first formal federal enforcement step aimed at how frontier labs handle and disclose autonomous-agent failures.

Sources: The Next Web: FTC subpoenas OpenAI and Anthropic over AI safety incidents; Seoul Economic Daily: U.S. FTC Probes OpenAI, Anthropic Over AI Security Breaches

TECHNOLOGY

Japan hit by wave of data breaches exposing millions of customers

Yamato, Nikkei, Times Car and others disclose fresh losses as Qilin ransomware group is blamed for at least one attack

The Japan Times (Reuters)

TOKYO — More Japanese companies disclosed customer data breaches on Friday, extending a run of cyberattacks that has put millions of people's personal information at risk. Yamato Transport said 5.31 million records tied to its deferred-payment service were compromised, covering about eight years from October 2018. Nikkei said about 1.83 million records, including names, addresses and email addresses, were exposed when a cloud service used for system development was accessed fraudulently. Park24, parent of the Times Car operator, said about 6.6 million records were affected, roughly 1.6 million of them including images of driver's licenses and similar documents. It will delete those images by the end of October. Railway operator Keio said attackers claimed to have published its data, and outside experts believe the Qilin ransomware group was responsible. Cosmetics maker Fancl reported about 830,000 affected customers. Further disclosures are likely as companies finish their investigations.

WHY IT MATTERS: Breaches at logistics, media, transport and retail firms show how one wave of attacks can spread across a national economy, and the exposed ID-document images raise the risk of identity fraud.

Sources: The Japan Times (Reuters)

Chinese state hackers exploited BeyondTrust remote-support flaw for weeks before disclosure

Critical zero-day in self-hosted appliances was used from late August; CISA lists it as exploited

SC Media

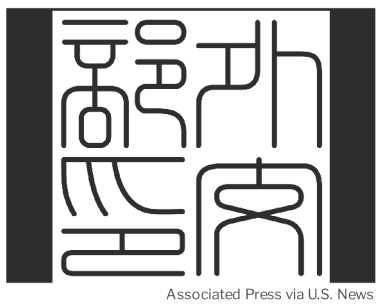
BeyondTrust disclosed on October 15 that a critical flaw in its Remote Support appliances had been exploited as a zero-day since late August. Google Threat Intelligence Group and Mandiant attribute the campaign to a suspected China-linked espionage group they call Armory Castle, previously tracked as UNC5221. The flaw, CVE-2026-102764, scores 9.3 on the CVSS scale. It stems from a component that failed to verify where messages came from, and it allows file operations on the appliance. Mandiant says the attackers gained root access, tried to harvest stored credentials, deployed custom backdoors and deleted logs. BeyondTrust says it has confirmed only two affected customers, but Google warns that others may have been compromised. SaaS customers were patched by October 9. Self-hosted customers on versions up to 26.2.3 must apply patch BT26-05, and older releases must be upgraded first. CISA has urged immediate patching.

WHY IT MATTERS: Remote-support appliances hold privileged credentials and reach into internal networks, so one compromise can open many downstream systems.

Sources: Cybersecurity Dive; SC Media

Taipei and Beijing both move to tighten technology export rules

Taiwan plans to criminalize AI-chip smuggling to China; China proposes curbs on 40 technologies including chip designs


Associated Press via U.S. News

TAIPEI — Taiwan plans to add AI servers and cutting-edge semiconductors to its list of controlled items, Economy Minister Kung Ming-hsin told Bloomberg. Once the measures take effect, shipping restricted AI hardware to China would become a crime under the Foreign Trade Act. Kung said the move follows commitments in Taiwan's trade agreement with the United States. He gave no start date. Taiwan indicted nine people in August, including an Nvidia manager, over the alleged smuggling of 130 AI servers, according to regional reports. Separately, on Friday China's commerce and science ministries published a draft that would restrict or ban exports of 40 technologies, including AI, chips and solar. The draft covers some chip-design and memory-chip know-how, and the ministry cited national security. A temporary export registration rule took effect on October 16. Public comment on the Chinese draft closes November 15.

WHY IT MATTERS: The two moves show chip controls spreading beyond Washington, with allies adopting criminal enforcement while Beijing builds its own export-control regime.

Sources: Bloomberg; Associated Press via U.S. News; Forkast

Apple's first foldable iPhone sells out within minutes of pre-orders

iPhone Duo, priced from $1,999, faces constrained supply; scalpers list units far above retail

9to5Mac

CUPERTINO — Apple opened pre-orders for the iPhone Duo, its first foldable phone, on Friday, and estimated delivery dates slipped within minutes. Launch-day delivery on October 23 disappeared almost at once. Some orders were quoted December dates, and others were quoted January 25, 2027. The phone starts at $1,999. 9to5Mac pointed to a combination of strong demand and tight supply, and noted a Nikkei Asia report from last month that Apple was producing only a few hundred units a day. PhoneArena reported eBay listings asking roughly $2,800 to $5,200. Apple has not published unit figures for pre-orders or production, so the sell-out does not show total demand. Pre-orders continue online, and the phone is due in stores October 23. The Seoul Economic Daily reported the same pattern in Korea, with delivery pushed to January.

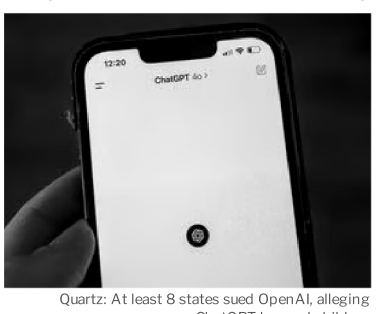
WHY IT MATTERS: The reception will show whether a premium foldable can become a mainstream product category for Apple, and the supply shortfall may push buyers toward Samsung and Chinese foldable rivals.

Sources: 9to5Mac; PhoneArena; Seoul Economic Daily

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Eight states sue OpenAI, alleging ChatGPT harmed children and misled parents

Separate state-court suits rest on consumer-protection law; Arkansas also asks for limits on advanced AI testing



Quartz: At least 8 states sued OpenAI, alleging ChatGPT harmed children

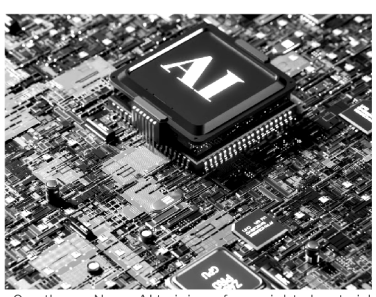
Attorneys general in Arizona, Arkansas, Idaho, Iowa, Kansas, Montana, Nebraska and West Virginia each sued OpenAI in their own state courts on Wednesday. They allege the company marketed ChatGPT as safe for minors while it gave dangerous medical advice and encouraged self-harm or violence. The suits rely mainly on state consumer-protection statutes. Arkansas adds negligence, strict-liability and public-nuisance claims. It also seeks an injunction against developing models capable of recursive self-improvement until safeguards exist. Iowa seeks up to $40,000 per violation. Nebraska seeks $50,000 per violation of its age-appropriate design law. West Virginia asks for age checks, default nighttime limits and an independent monitor. Arkansas's office also listed Utah as a filer, a ninth state that other offices did not name. OpenAI says no system is perfect and points to its teen protections. The allegations are unproven, and OpenAI must answer each complaint separately.

WHY IT MATTERS: Bipartisan state enforcement is setting chatbot child-safety rules through courts while Congress and the White House debate federal preemption.

Sources: Quartz: At least 8 states sued OpenAI, alleging ChatGPT harmed children; The Next Web: Eight US states sue OpenAI, alleging ChatGPT harms children

Appeals court ruling on AI training and fair use is narrower than headlines say

Third Circuit's Ross decision involved a non-generative tool; a Concord v. Anthropic hearing is due October 21



Courthouse News: AI training of copyrighted material not fair use, Third Circuit

PHILADELPHIA — On September 29 the Third Circuit affirmed that Ross Intelligence infringed Thomson Reuters' copyrights. Ross used Westlaw headnotes to train a competing legal-research tool, and the court held that this was not fair use. The panel called

the case an ordinary copyright dispute. It found Ross's use only minimally transformative and harmful to Westlaw's market, including a developing market for licensing training data. It is the first federal appellate decision on fair use in AI training. A footnote stresses that Ross's system generated no new text, setting it apart from the OpenAI, Anthropic and Meta cases. Law firms read the ruling as neither a ban on AI training nor a safe harbor. Ross says it will seek Supreme Court review. Cases involving generative models are still at trial level. A summary-judgment hearing in Concord Music Group v. Anthropic, over song lyrics, is set for October 21.

WHY IT MATTERS: It shows which facts courts weigh in AI training disputes: direct market competition, and whether a licensing market exists.

Sources: Third Circuit opinion, Thomson Reuters v. ROSS Intelligence, No. 25-2153 (via LawNext); Courthouse News: AI training of copyrighted material not fair use, Third Circuit; Jackson Walker: Training Day, Third Circuit affirms Westlaw headnotes decision

Google opens Gemini 4 Argon to paying users as OpenAI shelves a model

Vendor benchmark and price claims dominate a crowded month of releases; independent verification lags

CNBC: Can Google's new model really catch up to OpenAI and Anthropic?

Google announced Gemini 4 Argon on September 30. It said the model scored top-tier benchmark results and set a record on a long-horizon software-engineering test. Access began with cybersecurity partners. Release trackers report that Google widened access to paying API and subscriber customers on October 13. Independent testing of the vendor's claims is still thin. Analysts told CNBC that its real test comes in broad production use. CNBC also reported that OpenAI abandoned an upcoming model after concluding it fell short of the company's safety standards. OpenAI instead released cheaper GPT-6 Sol and Luna on September 22, with API prices cut 50% from the earlier GPT-5.6 promotional rates. OpenAI says Sol at maximum effort beats Anthropic's Claude Opus 5 on AutomationBench at 9% of the cost per task. That is the company's own comparison, not an independent result.

WHY IT MATTERS: Frontier labs are competing on cost and staged, security-first access, and the safety-driven cancellation shows release decisions now carry regulatory weight.

Sources: CNBC: Can Google's new model really catch up to OpenAI and Anthropic?; OpenAI: Introducing GPT-6 Sol and Luna

White House 'Super Intelligence' order leaves state AI laws untouched

Executive orders alone do not preempt state law, so states keep enforcing as federal litigation and legislation lag

Wiley: Executive Order Rebrands AI as 'Super Intelligence'

WASHINGTON — President Trump's Executive Order 14434, signed September 29, directs agencies to say 'Super Intelligence' instead of 'Artificial Intelligence' in official communications. Wiley's client alert notes it does not expressly address preemption of state AI laws. It adds that preemption could come in a legislative package being prepared for the President. The state-law fight rests on the December 2025 order, which created a Justice Department AI Litigation Task Force. The task force was announced January 9. Law firms stress that an executive order cannot itself override state statutes, and that agency or funding routes may be challenged in court. Congress has not passed preemption. The December order exempts state child-safety rules from its preemption push, the area of this week's eight-state suits against OpenAI. Until courts or Congress act, state laws and state consumer-protection enforcement remain in force.

WHY IT MATTERS: Companies face an unsettled mix of federal signals and active state enforcement, with no binding federal standard.

Sources: Wiley: Executive Order Rebrands AI as 'Super Intelligence'; White House: Ensuring a National Policy Framework for Artificial Intelligence; Ropes & Gray: Limitations of the Federal Push to Override State AI Regulation

SCIENCE

Alaska camp dated to 13,800 years yields oldest known Americas dwelling

Peer-reviewed excavation report describes 80,000-plus finds, bone needles and possible early dogs near Fairbanks

Live Science

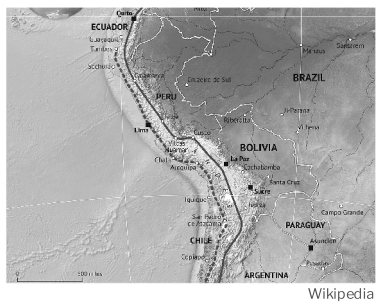
FAIRBANKS, ALASKA — Archaeologists led by Kelly Graf of the University of Kansas have reported a base camp in interior Alaska that was first occupied about 13,800 years ago. The site is called Shég' Xdaltth'í', and it lies about 55 kilometers southeast of Fairbanks. The report appeared Oct. 14 in the peer-reviewed journal Science Advances. The team describes three occupation layers, dated to roughly 13,800, 13,000 and 12,700 years ago, and more than 80,000 specimens. The oldest layer holds what the authors call the earliest potential dwelling in North America, with a hearth, an earth oven and a post stain. It also holds bone needle fragments, diamond-shaped stone blades with Siberian parallels and the remains of more than a dozen wolf-like canids. The canids offer only circumstantial evidence that people kept dogs. Further analysis of the canid bones is the next step.

WHY IT MATTERS: A long-used, well-equipped camp suggests the first Americans settled in more than they passed through, and it ties them to Siberia.

Sources: Live Science; Nautilus; Archaeology Magazine (summary of Graf et al., Science Advances 12(42))

New radiocarbon dates stretch Inca empire's timeline and point to resistance

Science cover story says the traditional chronology has collapsed; the work is a news feature on accumulating data, not one study



Wikipedia

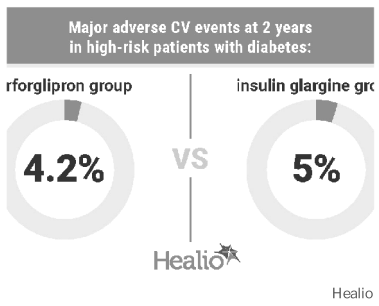
Science devoted its Oct. 15 cover to the argument that the Inca empire lasted longer than long believed. The accepted timeline rests on a Spanish colonial chronicle. That chronicle held that the empire ran only 94 years, from its founding to the Spanish conquest that began in 1532, and met little opposition. The magazine reports that radiocarbon dates from sites along the Qhapaq Ñan road system now contradict this. One example is the outpost of Chamical in Argentina. Archaeologist Dennis Ogburn dated seed, wood and charcoal from its earliest layers to between 1432 and 1451, decades before the traditional date. Archaeologists in Argentina had also reported dates more than 50 years early. Their findings were long met with skepticism. The article presents the earlier dates as evidence of local resistance to Inca expansion in the 15th century. Ogburn first urged building a chronology from radiocarbon dates alone in a 2012 paper in Radiocarbon.

WHY IT MATTERS: A longer imperial timeline changes how historians understand how the Inca conquered, and how far conquered peoples resisted.

Sources: Science (news feature, 'Redating the Inca empire'); Science, issue 394(6821) contents; Ogburn, 'Reconceiving the chronology of Inca imperial expansion', Radiocarbon (2012)

Lancet trial: Lilly's GLP-1 pill matches insulin on heart safety in diabetics

Phase 3 ACHIEVE-4 enrolled 2,749 high-risk patients; open-label and sponsor-run, designed to test safety, not benefit



Healio

The Lancet published results on Sept. 30 from ACHIEVE-4, a phase 3 trial of Eli Lilly's oral drug orforglipron, sold as Foundayo. The trial randomly assigned 2,749 adults with type 2 diabetes, overweight or obesity, and established heart or kidney disease to the pill or to insulin glargine. The primary goal was non-inferiority on major adverse cardiovascular events, and the drug met it. Lilly reports a 16 percent lower risk on the four-part measure, though the trial was built to rule out excess harm, not to show protection. The company says its pill also reduced blood sugar and weight more than insulin. In the published paper, the average difference in body weight was 8.9 percent. At week 52, 65.7 percent of pill users and 46.0 percent of insulin users had HbA1c below 7 percent. Lilly reports that 10.6 percent of pill users stopped treatment because of side effects. Nausea, vomiting and diarrhea were the most common.

WHY IT MATTERS: It is the first large heart-safety result for a non-peptide GLP-1 pill, which bears on how widely oral diabetes and obesity drugs can be prescribed.

Sources: Eli Lilly press release (ACHIEVE-4 detailed results); The Lancet, issue of Oct. 17, 2026 (Klein et al., ACHIEVE-4); Healio

SPACE EXPLORATION

NASA to detail Artemis speed-up and 2028 Moon landing plan Friday

Kennedy briefing will cover next year's Artemis III Earth-orbit test, a rehearsal for the lunar landing mission

NASA 2026 News Releases

CAPE CANAVERAL, FLA. — NASA will brief reporters at 2 p.m. EDT on Friday, Oct. 23, at Kennedy Space Center on how it plans to land astronauts on the Moon by 2028. Administrator Jared Isaacman, Associate Administrator Amit Kshatriya and Artemis program manager Jeremy Parsons are scheduled to take part. The update centers on Artemis III, a 2027 mission that will send four astronauts into low Earth orbit. They are to dock with test versions of the Blue Origin and SpaceX landers, which are still in development. NASA named the crew in June: Randy Bresnik, Frank Rubio, Andre Douglas and ESA's Luca Parmitano. A Congressional Research Service review notes that NASA's inspector general has flagged schedule and technical risks for both landers. It also notes that Blue Origin's May rocket explosion raised questions about Artemis III timing. The agency has not said what new details it will present.

WHY IT MATTERS: The briefing is the best near-term test of whether NASA's 2028 lunar landing date, which depends on two unfinished commercial landers, is still credible.

Sources: NASA 2026 News Releases; Congressional Research Service: Artemis, NASA's Program to Return Humans to the Moon; Al Jazeera: NASA announces astronauts for Artemis III

Starship's next flight slips to mid-November after first orbital success

SpaceX has set no firm date for Flight 15, and a Mars attempt this year is off the table

Space.com: Starship just turned 10 years old. When will it go to Mars?

STARBASE, TEXAS — SpaceX has not announced a date for Starship's 15th flight. A provisional Oct. 19 target has slipped, and Space.com now reports mid-to-late November, with no firm date confirmed. Flight 14 on Sept. 28 was the first time Starship reached orbit. It was also the first mission to carry Starlink V3 satellites on the giant rocket. Space.com says the once-every-26-months Mars launch window opens in late October, but SpaceX has not yet demonstrated propellant transfer, so a 2026 Mars run is ruled out. SpaceX's Julianna Scheiman said on Oct. 1 that at least one more Starship test will fly from Texas before the first launch from Florida's Pad 39A. She said that pad's new tower is nearly complete. The ship is due to fly in the 2027 Artemis III docking test.

WHY IT MATTERS: Starship's reliability and propellant-transfer progress decide whether NASA's Moon schedule holds and whether SpaceX can start Florida launches.

Sources: Space.com: Starship just turned 10 years old. When will it go to Mars?; Space.com: Things are going super well at 39A; Spaceflight Now: Launch preview, first Starlink V3 satellites on Starship

Blue Origin plans more Florida pads while New Glenn remains grounded

Company outlines $330 million factory expansion and seeks FAA approval for 50 launches a year

CNBC: Blue Origin plans $330 million Florida expansion

CAPE CANAVERAL, FLA. — Blue Origin said Friday it will add two New Glenn launch pads on Florida's Space Coast. They would join the two at Launch Complex 36, where LC-36A is being rebuilt after a catastrophic May test-fire explosion and LC-36B is under construction. The company is spending $330 million to expand its Rocket Park factory, due for completion in summer 2027. The expansion is meant to allow production of up to 150 upper stages a year. Executive Ian Richardson said the infrastructure is designed to support multiple flights per week by the end of the decade. The FAA is taking public comment on a request to raise LC-36A's permitted launches from 12 to 50 a year. Jeff Bezos has said he still wants New Glenn flying again before year's end. The company has not given a firm return-to-flight date.

WHY IT MATTERS: New Glenn must fly again for Blue Origin to deliver the lander test article for Artemis III and to compete with SpaceX's launch dominance.

Sources: Spaceflight Now: Blue Origin to add new Florida launch pads; Blue Origin: Building the Infrastructure for More Frequent Launches in Florida; CNBC: Blue Origin plans $330 million Florida expansion

LAW & COURTS

SCOTUSblog: Court appears likely to allow internet suit based on decades-old video privacy law

Justices weigh Paramount video-privacy case from Nashville federal court

Salazar v. Paramount Global tests whether a 1988 law covers Facebook pixel tracking on websites

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court heard argument Wednesday in Salazar v. Paramount Global (No. 25-459). Michael Salazar says Paramount's 247Sports.com site used a Facebook pixel to send his video-viewing history to Facebook without consent, violating the Video Privacy Protection Act. The Middle District of Tennessee in Nashville dismissed the class action, and the Sixth Circuit affirmed. Both courts held that a subscription to an email newsletter did not make him a "consumer" under the statute. The law allows $2,500 in damages per violation. Reports on the argument differ. SCOTUSblog and Bloomberg Law said the justices seemed inclined to side with Salazar, with Justices Kagan and Kavanaugh noting that companies can simply obtain consent. The Daily Record described the bench as skeptical of his reading. Justice Barrett also raised standing. A decision is expected by the end of the term.

WHY IT MATTERS: The ruling will determine how widely the VPPA can be used in class actions over website tracking, a significant exposure for any business that runs video content and ad pixels.

Sources: SCOTUSblog: Court appears likely to allow internet suit based on decades-old video privacy law; Bloomberg Law: Paramount Video Privacy Win in Doubt at SCOTUS Oral Argument; The Daily Record: Supreme Court to decide if video privacy law applies to online data sharing

LAW

Supreme Court halts 48-hour deadline imposed on FCC in ad-rate dispute

Per curiam order in FCC v. Brown says Fourth Circuit intruded on agency's control of its own process

Wikipedia

WASHINGTON — On October 14 the Supreme Court issued an unsigned per curiam order in FCC v. Brown (No. 26A476) staying a Fourth Circuit mandamus order. The appeals court had required the Federal Communications Commission to resolve an application for review within 48 hours. The justices said that order improperly interfered with the Commission's discretion over the timing and procedures of its deliberations. The dispute concerns discounted broadcast ad rates for political parties and party committees. Democratic candidates had asked the justices to leave the appeals court ruling in place, according to SCOTUSblog. Another report on the order said Justices Sotomayor and Jackson would have denied the stay, but that account was not independently confirmed from the Court's own materials. The merits appeal continues in the lower courts.

WHY IT MATTERS: The order reinforces limits on courts setting deadlines for federal agencies, and it arrives weeks before the midterm elections.

Sources: Supreme Court of the United States: Recent Decisions, FCC v. Brown (26A476); Cornell Legal Information Institute: Supreme Court recent decisions; SCOTUSblog

Federal judge clears state takeover of Memphis-Shelby County Schools

Judge Waverly Crenshaw dissolves his June block as the underlying lawsuit continues

Wikipedia

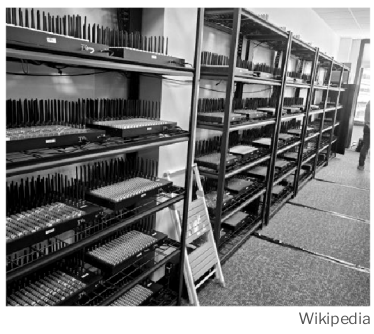
MEMPHIS — U.S. District Judge Waverly Crenshaw Jr. on Thursday, October 15, dissolved the temporary restraint he issued in late June against Tennessee's takeover of Memphis-Shelby County Schools. He acted days after the nine-member state Educational Oversight Board told the court it was ready to perform its duties. Under the Public School Accountability Act, the board can override major district decisions, including adopting budgets, closing schools and appointing a superintendent. The elected district board would serve in an advisory role. Board chair Billy Orgel said the body is ready to begin work. District board chair Tamarques Porter said he disagrees with the ruling and that the legal process continues. The case challenging the takeover remains pending, and no further hearings have been scheduled. Both sides will need to present evidence as it proceeds.

WHY IT MATTERS: A federal court has, for now, handed control of Shelby County's largest public institution to a state-appointed board, with the merits still undecided.

Sources: Chalkbeat Tennessee: Judge lifts block on Memphis schools state takeover as lawsuit continues; The Daily Memphian: MSCS takeover can proceed, judge rules; Memphis Flyer: Judge Lifts Block on Memphis Schools State Takeover

Courts keep narrowing TCPA do-not-call suits over text messages

Seventh Circuit ruling in Steidinger spreads through district courts, but Section 227(b) claims survive



Wikipedia

Federal courts are increasingly holding that the Telephone Consumer Protection Act's do-not-call private right of action does not reach text messages. The Seventh Circuit led in Steidinger v. Blackstone Medical Services (July 14, 2026), finding that a "telephone call" in Section 227(c)(5) did not include texts in 1991. District courts in the Fourth Circuit and in Colorado, along with other courts, have followed. On September 11, Judge Aileen Cannon of the Southern District of Florida ruled that cell phone users are not "residential" subscribers for do-not-call claims. Texts remain actionable under the Section 227(b) autodialer and prerecorded-voice provisions. On October 1, the Southern District of Texas, in Taylor v. OffersPDQ, granted a default judgment on a 227(b) text claim but not on a 227(c) claim. California federal courts are cited as holdouts. Separately, the FCC has pushed the effective date of its revoke-all consent rule to January 31, 2027.

WHY IT MATTERS: For lead-generation and marketing firms, exposure to text-message class actions now depends on which statutory provision is invoked and which circuit the suit is filed in.

Sources: Duane Morris Class Action Defense: TCPA Class Action Litigation; Sheppard Mullin: Seventh Circuit Holds TCPA Do-Not-Call Claims Do Not Cover Text Messages; TCPAWorld (Troutman Amin)

MEMPHIS

Wikimedia Commons

Judge lifts block on state takeover of Memphis schools

Appointed board can now run MSCS budget, contracts and closures while the district's lawsuit continues

MEMPHIS — U.S. District Judge Waverly Crenshaw on Thursday dissolved the temporary order he issued in late June that had kept the state-appointed oversight board from taking over Memphis-Shelby County Schools. The ruling came days after board chair Billy Orgel told the court in a filing that the nine-member panel was ready to operate. The board can now direct major decisions, including adopting the annual budget, closing schools, approving contracts over $50,000 and choosing a superintendent. At an Oct. 2 hearing, Crenshaw said the district had not shown enough evidence of harm to students. He also dismissed the governor, the education commissioner and legislative leaders as defendants. The district's broader challenge to the state law continues. At the Oct. 8 meeting, one board member questioned approving policies written by a consultant, MGT, outside public view.

WHY IT MATTERS: Tennessee's largest school district is now under the authority of an appointed panel, which changes who sets its budget and who can close schools.

Sources: Chalkbeat Tennessee: Judge lifts block on Memphis schools state takeover; Chalkbeat Tennessee: Takeover board says it is ready to assume control; Chalkbeat Tennessee: Takeover could move forward soon (Oct. 2 hearing)

MEMPHIS & SHELBY COUNTY POLITICS

City Council faces Tuesday vote on data center moratorium

After a chaotic Oct. 6 meeting, the council and County Commission are both moving on a one-year pause

Action News 5: 'Low point': Council finishes Tuesday's meeting

MEMPHIS — The Memphis City Council is due to take up a proposed 12-month data center moratorium on Tuesday, Oct. 20. On Oct. 6 the council voted 7-5 to put off the vote. Protesters, who expected a decision, then shouted in the chamber. A fight broke out in the City Hall lobby, and police cleared the room. Council members held a working session Thursday on five competing ordinances, including ones from J.B. Smiley and Philip Spinosa. Councilwoman Janika White said the moratorium would likely have failed on Oct. 6 without that extra work. Separately, the Shelby County Commission on Oct. 12 passed the first reading of a similar pause for unincorporated areas by 5-4, with four abstentions. Commissioner Amber Huett-Garcia plans an alternative regulation-only ordinance on Oct. 21. The Greater Memphis Chamber opposes a moratorium.

WHY IT MATTERS: The vote could set rules for the data center industry, including xAI's facilities in Southwest Memphis, and shows how divided officials are over growth versus health and environmental concerns.

Sources: WREG: Fight erupts during council meeting about moratorium; vote delayed; Action News 5: 'Low point': Council finishes Tuesday's meeting; Local Memphis (ABC24): County Commission passes first reading of moratorium

MLGW proposes three years of steep gas and water rate hikes

Board votes Oct. 21; City Council has final say in late November

FOX13 Memphis: MLGW plans water and gas rate hikes starting next year

MEMPHIS — Memphis Light, Gas and Water presented a preliminary fiscal 2027 budget on Oct. 7 that includes three straight years of gas and water rate increases. Gas would rise 11% a year for 2027 through 2029. Local Memphis (ABC24) reported water increases of 13% in 2027 and 16% in each of the next two years, about 52% compounded. FOX13 reported 16% for each year. CEO Doug McGowen attributed the increases to years of underfunding and deferred maintenance, not to data centers. The overall budget is expected to grow about 3%. The MLGW board votes Oct. 21. The proposal then goes to the City Council, with committee review in mid-November and a final vote tentatively set for Nov. 24. Some residents have also complained about unusually high October bills. MLGW buys its power from the Tennessee Valley Authority, which saw record demand in September.

WHY IT MATTERS: Higher utility bills land on households already complaining about bills, and the council will make the final decision.

Sources: Local Memphis (ABC24): MLGW proposes gas, water rate hike for 2027-2029; FOX13 Memphis: MLGW plans water and gas rate hikes starting next year; Action News 5: Memphis residents question soaring MLGW utility bills

Rep. Justin Pearson sues Memphis over City Council ban

Federal suit alleges council public-comment rules violate First Amendment

Tennessee Lookout: Rep. Pearson sues Memphis alleging First Amendment violation

MEMPHIS — State Rep. Justin J. Pearson, the Democratic nominee for Tennessee's 9th Congressional District, sued the city of Memphis on Tuesday in U.S. District Court for West Tennessee. He is challenging a two-meeting ban from City Council sessions. Six other plaintiffs join him, including his brother Keshaun Pearson and his mother, Kimberly Owens-Pearson. They argue the council's public comment policies unconstitutionally restrict speech and that the council chair, Jana Swearengen-Washington, retaliated against people who disagreed with her. Pearson said everyone has a right to speak at public forums whether or not officials agree with them. The city has not been quoted in the available coverage. The suit follows the Oct. 6 council meeting that ended with police clearing the chamber. Early voting for the Nov. 3 election runs through Oct. 29.

WHY IT MATTERS: The suit could test how far the council may restrict public comment, as data center and utility fights draw crowds to City Hall.

Sources: Tennessee Lookout: Rep. Pearson sues Memphis alleging First Amendment violation; Daily Memphian: Nov. 3 midterm voter guide

MEMPHIS EVENTS

Grizzlies open 2026-27 season at FedExForum against Jaren Jackson Jr.'s Jazz

Wed., Oct. 21, 7 p.m., FedExForum, 191 Beale St.; ticket listings on Ticketmaster

Ticketmaster: Memphis Grizzlies home schedule

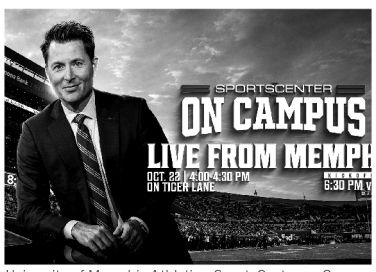
MEMPHIS — The Memphis Grizzlies begin their 82-game season Wednesday night at home against the Utah Jazz, with tip-off set for 7 p.m. Central. The game is the Jazz's only trip to FedExForum this season. It also brings former Grizzlies big man Jaren Jackson Jr., now with Utah, back to Memphis, and it is rookie Cam Boozer's first regular-season game in the building. The team closed the preseason at home Friday against Charlotte. The Grizzlies are running a free 'Grizz Week' of community events leading up to the opener, including a Junior Grizzlies youth clinic at Tom Lee Park for children ages 6 to 14, plus merchandise and ticket giveaways. Memphis then goes on the road for four games before returning home Oct. 31 to face Sacramento.

WHY IT MATTERS: The opener starts a rebuilt Grizzlies era and is the week's biggest ticketed event downtown.

Sources: Ticketmaster: Memphis Grizzlies home schedule; FOX13 Memphis: Grizz Week events; I Love Memphis Blog: Grizzlies 2026-27 schedule

ESPN brings 'SportsCenter on Campus' to Tiger Lane for Memphis-ECU Thursday game

Thu., Oct. 22, 6:30 p.m. kickoff, Simmons Bank Liberty Stadium; ESPN2; tickets via Memphis Ticket Office, (901) 678-2331



University of Memphis Athletics: SportsCenter on Campus release

MEMPHIS — Memphis hosts East Carolina in an American Conference game Thursday at 6:30 p.m. Central at the renovated Simmons Bank Liberty Stadium. ESPN2 will televise it. ESPN's 'SportsCenter on Campus' will broadcast live from Tiger Lane from 4 to 4:30 p.m., hosted by Matt Barrie and Chase Daniel. Tiger Lane parking lots open at noon, and a kids' zone with yard games and inflatables opens at 3:30 p.m. The game is the university's Pink Game, the third straight year of a partnership with the DeAngelo Williams Foundation, which funds breast cancer research and care. Single-game tickets are sold online through the athletics site or by phone at the Memphis Ticket Office. The Tigers are in Charles Huff's first season as head coach.

WHY IT MATTERS: A national TV window and a rare ESPN pregame visit put the Tigers' home weeknight game in the spotlight.

Sources: University of Memphis Athletics: SportsCenter on Campus release; Local Memphis (ABC24)

Symphony and Opera Memphis stage Verdi's 'Rigoletto' in concert at Cannon Center

Sat., Oct. 24, 7:30 p.m., Cannon Center for the Performing Arts, 255 N. Main St.; tickets at memphissymphony.org

Orpheum Theatre Memphis: events calendar

MEMPHIS — The Memphis Symphony Orchestra and Opera Memphis present Verdi's 'Rigoletto' in a concert performance Saturday, Oct. 24, at 7:30 p.m. at the Cannon Center. Music Director Robert Moody conducts. The concert format puts the score at center stage rather than a full staging. It is the first collaboration between the two companies in the orchestra's 75th season, which Moody has called a landmark year. Downtown has other events the same day. The Día de Muertos Parade & Festival is free and includes live music, dance, Catrinas, art activities and community altars. The Orpheum is also hosting Sarah Jakes Roberts' Rogue Route Tour that night, and Morris Day & The Time with The S.O.S. Band on Sunday, Oct. 25.

WHY IT MATTERS: The collaboration gives Memphis a rare large-scale opera night in its 75th symphony season, alongside a busy downtown Saturday.

Sources: Memphis Symphony Orchestra: Rigoletto in Concert; Orpheum Theatre Memphis: events calendar; WKNO: Moody previews the MSO's 75th season

Dixon's 'Hot Off the Wall' art sale opens Tuesday, leading to Art on Fire

Oct. 20-25 during museum hours, Dixon Gallery & Gardens, 4339 Park Ave.; Art on Fire is Sat., Oct. 24, 7-11 p.m.

Dixon Gallery & Gardens: Hot Off the Wall event page

MEMPHIS — The Dixon Gallery & Gardens' annual art sale runs Tuesday, Oct. 20, through Sunday, Oct. 25. The public can browse and buy original works by nationally known and emerging artists during regular museum hours. Proceeds benefit the Dixon's education programs. The sale is tied to the museum's fall fundraiser, Art on Fire, on Saturday, Oct. 24, from 7 to 11 p.m. Admission includes food from more than 20 local restaurants and caterers, beer, wine, whiskey and specialty drinks, live entertainment, a silent auction and access to the sale. A VIP experience, The Hotspot, runs Friday, Oct. 23, from 7 to 10 p.m. Ticket details are on the Dixon's Art on Fire page. Two exhibitions are also on view: 'An Investment in Pleasure' and 'Mallory/Wurtzburger: 80 Exhibitions, 18 Years.'

WHY IT MATTERS: The sale lets buyers collect original art while funding the museum's art-education work across Memphis.

Sources: Dixon Gallery & Gardens: Art on Fire; Dixon Gallery & Gardens: Hot Off the Wall event page; WKNO: Dixon's Art on Fire supports arts education

IDEAS

ABC7 (AP): Faithful welcome Pope Leo back for Sunday blessing

Pope Leo returns to the Angelus after lung cancer surgery

The pontiff says he will resume duties gradually. Further treatment depends on pathology results, and the Vatican is still weighing his November trip.

VATICAN CITY — Pope Leo XIV appeared at his window above St. Peter's Square on Sunday. He thanked the faithful for their prayers and said he would gradually resume his activities. His voice sounded strong four days after surgeons removed the lower lobe of his right lung. Doctors confirmed adenocarcinoma, the most common type of lung cancer. He left Rome's Gemelli hospital on Saturday. His surgeon said no clinical reasons stand in the way of a Nov. 6-17 trip to Uruguay, Argentina and Peru, and expects full recovery in about ten days. Testing of the tumor and lymph nodes is still underway. It will determine whether he needs chemotherapy, immunotherapy or targeted therapy. From hospital on Friday the pope also phoned Vladimir Putin. He asked for a local ceasefire in Oleshky, a Russian-held Kherson city where about 2,000 civilians are reportedly short of food. The Kremlin said the two agreed to cooperate on aid. Ukrainian officials say Russia has not yet confirmed an evacuation.

WHY IT MATTERS: The health of the leader of 1.4 billion Catholics, and his role as a channel to Moscow, bear on both church governance and the war in Ukraine.

Sources: NPR (AP): Pope Leo says he will gradually resume duties; ABC7 (AP): Faithful welcome Pope Leo back for Sunday blessing; Vatican News: Pope urges humanitarian ceasefire in Oleshky in call with Putin

RELIGION & PHILOSOPHY

Supreme Court's new term tests limits of religious exemptions

Justices have taken a Kentucky shrine dispute and a Colorado preschool case. An Ohio home-worship case is also pending.

TNND: Supreme Court term brings cases on climate claims, gun rights, religious liberty

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court has built a religion-heavy docket for its 2026-27 term. On Oct. 1 it agreed to hear Missionaries of St. John the Baptist v. Frederic. Catholic priests in Park Hills, Kentucky, want to build a grotto shrine to the Virgin Mary beside their church. Kentucky's Supreme Court held that the zoning ban did not violate the federal land-use law RLUIPA. It reasoned that a smaller shrine elsewhere would be allowed. The justices will decide whether a ban at the chosen site is a "substantial burden" on religious exercise. The court also has St. Mary Catholic Parish v. Roy. In it, Colorado says its nondiscrimination condition for universal pre-K funding is neutral. The parishes say it burdens their faith by requiring them to admit children of LGBTQ families. A third case, Grand v. City of University Heights, concerns threats over home worship in Ohio. Supporters call the trend a restoration of religious liberty. Critics say it erodes church-state separation. Rulings are expected by summer 2027.

WHY IT MATTERS: The rulings will decide how far houses of worship and religious schools must follow zoning and anti-discrimination rules.

Sources: The Washington Times: Supreme Court agrees to hear religious liberty case over shrine; Oyez: Free exercise of religion cases; TNND: Supreme Court term brings cases on climate claims, gun rights, religious liberty

Theos survey finds British 'Christian nationalism' is more cultural than devout

A new UK study splits the public into five groups. Humanists UK disputes the report's reading of its own figures.

Humanists UK: We can't tackle Christian nationalism by pretending it isn't Christian

LONDON — The think tank Theos has published Beyond "Christian Nationalism", based on an April 2026 survey of 1,765 UK adults. It sorts respondents into five groups. Committed Separatists are 34 per cent and Cultural Separatists 16 per cent. Values Integrationists are 26 per cent, Belief Integrationists 13 per cent and Identity Integrationists 11 per cent. Theos treats the Identity group as the closest to Christian nationalism. Only 13 per cent of that group attend church weekly, against 11 per cent of the whole sample, and 82 per cent of it endorse the "Great Replacement" conspiracy theory. Belief Integrationists, the most devout group at 31 per cent weekly attendance, are the most likely to want faith promoted in public life. Two-thirds of them also accept that theory. Humanists UK argues that about half of weekly churchgoers sit in the two groups most sympathetic to the idea, so it cannot be separated from Christianity. Academic John Heathershaw calls the methodology rigorous.

WHY IT MATTERS: The study gives empirical data to a heated debate over religion, identity and the far right in Britain, and bears on similar arguments in America.

Sources: Church Times: Attitudes to Christianity and Britishness reflect deep anxiety, Theos report says; Humanists UK: We can't tackle Christian nationalism by pretending it isn't Christian; John Heathershaw (Substack): Beyond "Christian Nationalism"?

ARTS & CULTURE

NL Times: Mondrian's Composition III fetches €29 million

Restituted Kandinsky and first-time Mondrian lead $289 million Christie's London night

Evening sales total £219 million, about double last year, as bidding concentrates on a few museum-grade works

LONDON — Christie's 20th and 21st Century evening sales in London on Wednesday raised about £219 million ($289 million). That was roughly double last year's equivalent total, though it sat toward the low end of the house's expectations. Wassily Kandinsky's 1907 painting Das bunte Leben sold for £31.56 million after a Nazi-era restitution case. Germany returned it to the heirs of its original owner in 2023. Piet Mondrian's Composition III (1920), at auction for the first time and unseen in public for 25 years, sold for £25.2 million with fees, inside its £20-30 million estimate. Seven artist records were set, including for Bridget Riley and Liubov Popova. Italian coverage noted that the two top lots made up over half the total, and that many lesser lots were withdrawn or unsold. Sotheby's New York opens its Magnum Opus sale series on October 21.

WHY IT MATTERS: The sale suggests the top of the art market is recovering, while demand below the trophy tier remains thin.

Sources: ARTnews: Christie's London Sales Bring in $289 M.; NL Times: Mondrian's Composition III fetches €29 million; Il Sole 24 Ore: Kandinsky and Mondrian lead the way at Christie's

ARTS

Frieze closes in London as Sotheby's sale shows a selective, cautious market

De Kooning tops a £46 million evening, but six lots go unsold and several younger artists struggle

Artcentron: Sotheby's London Contemporary Art Auction Raises £45.9 Million

LONDON — Frieze London and Frieze Masters close today in Regent's Park after five days. The two fairs drew nearly 300 galleries: 172 at Frieze London and about 140 at Frieze Masters. Sotheby's London contemporary evening sale on Thursday raised about £46 million ($61 million) with fees. The hammer total of £36.9 million fell below the £41.7 million low estimate. A 1977 Willem de Kooning untitled abstraction led at £9.8 million, followed by a Gerhard Richter at £6.7 million. Of 34 lots offered, six went unsold, including works by Jadé Fadojutimi and Lynette Yiadom-Boakye. A Yayoi Kusama sold well below its estimate. Records were set for a Michael Andrews work on paper (£704,000) and for a David Hockney iPad drawing (about £1.9 million). Sotheby's Hockney sale, 20 Flowers from Normandy, runs online in London through October 27.

WHY IT MATTERS: Results show collectors paying up for scarce, established names while pricing younger and mid-career artists more cautiously.

Sources: Artcentron: Sotheby's London Contemporary Art Auction Raises £45.9 Million; Frieze London & Frieze Masters visitor information; Forbes: Frieze London 2026, 12 artworks and artists to look out for

Memphis Art Museum sets December 6 opening for Herzog & de Meuron riverfront home

Former Brooks museum moves downtown to a 123,500-square-foot campus; Shelby County residents get free admission

ArchDaily: Construction Advances on Memphis Art Museum

MEMPHIS — The Memphis Brooks Museum of Art will open its new downtown campus on December 6, rebranded as the Memphis Art Museum. The Swiss firm Herzog & de Meuron designed the building with Memphis firm archimania as architect of record, and OLIN designed the landscape. The 123,500-square-foot museum sits on the Mississippi bluff at Union Avenue and Front Street. It adds 50 percent more gallery space and, per the museum, six times as much free, art-filled public space. That includes a 10,000-square-foot courtyard and a 50,000-square-foot rooftop sculpture garden. Galleries will be organized into 18 exhibitions. ARTnews reported an initial cost of $180 million, with the city contributing $30 million and the state $12 million. Shelby County residents will be admitted free. Trade press describes it as among the first major U.S. museums built with laminated timber.

WHY IT MATTERS: The project is among the largest cultural investments in Memphis in years and will reshape the downtown riverfront.

Sources: Memphis Art Museum press release (Oct. 30, 2025); ARTnews: Memphis Art Museum Announces Opening Date; ArchDaily: Construction Advances on Memphis Art Museum

BOOKS

Faber stops supplying Sally Rooney's books in UK over terror-law bind

Publisher says it cannot lawfully pass on earnings the author has pledged to Palestine Action

Al Jazeera

LONDON — Faber announced Wednesday that it will no longer supply Sally Rooney's work in the United Kingdom in any format. The publisher said current law leaves it unable to pass UK earnings to the Irish novelist, which it called an unconscionable position. Rooney has said she intends to direct her income to Palestine Action, which Britain proscribed as a terrorist organisation in July 2025. Providing financial support to a proscribed group is a criminal offence. Rooney said she agreed to the move and is prepared to accept the consequences. E-books are gone from UK sale, though printed copies remain in some shops. Campaign Against Antisemitism says it reported her to counterterrorism police. Palestine Action's co-founder and several MPs criticised the ban. The UK Supreme Court is due to hear a further appeal against the proscription early next month.

WHY IT MATTERS: The case shows a counterterrorism law reaching a major author's catalogue and puts publishers' legal exposure for authors' political donations in focus.

Sources: Al Jazeera; CBS News; Time

Anne Carson's Nobel win sets up a crowded run of fall book prizes

Canadian poet and classicist honored; Booker winner due Nov. 9, National Book Awards Nov. 18

Publishers Weekly

STOCKHOLM — The Swedish Academy awarded the 2026 Nobel Prize in Literature on October 8 to Canadian poet, essayist and classicist Anne Carson, 76. It cited her work's playful dialogue with the classical tradition and the new forms it created. Publishers Weekly noted she is the third Canadian laureate, after Alice Munro and Saul Bellow. The committee singled out her debut, Eros the Bittersweet, and her latest collection, Wrong Norma, from New Directions. The academy's secretary said Carson was in Iceland when notified. Two more major prizes follow. The Booker Prize winner will be named November 9, from a shortlist including Marlon James's The Disappearers (Riverhead), Douglas Stuart's John of John (Grove) and Elizabeth Strout's The Things We Never Say (Random House). The National Book Awards will be presented November 18 in New York, with Salman Rushdie receiving a lifetime medal.

WHY IT MATTERS: A Nobel for a genre-crossing poet changes sales and attention for a small-press catalogue just as the fall prize season peaks.

Sources: Publishers Weekly; Al Jazeera; Publishers Weekly: 2026 Booker Prize shortlist

Palestinian-American authors pull children's book from Random House over edits

Dispute centered on how the manuscript treated Oct. 7, 2023; Interlink Books to publish in 2027

Dawn Images (reporting The Guardian)

NEW YORK — Alana Hadid and Jenan Matari have withdrawn Displacement and the Palestinian American Story from Random House Children's Books, a Penguin Random House division, days before its planned release. The Guardian reported the dispute Thursday, based on drafts and emails the authors supplied. Written for ages 10 to 13 and part of the Race to the Truth series, it was due out in September. The authors say an editor added a line calling the October 7, 2023, Hamas attacks a violation of international law, which they rejected. A Random House spokesperson said the process followed standard bookmaking

procedures and that the publisher respects the authors' decision and remains committed to Palestinian perspectives. The authors will publish with Palestinian-owned Interlink Books in 2027 under the title Understanding Palestine for Young Readers: A Palestinian American Perspective. The series co-creator, Saira Rao, said she will not work further with Random House.

WHY IT MATTERS: The dispute raises questions about editorial control over contested history in books for young readers at the largest trade publisher.

Sources: Dawn Images (reporting The Guardian); The New Arab; The Media Line

MOVIES

A24's Elizabeth Holmes documentary outdraws expectations as 'Street Fighter' wins weekend

'You Can See Everything' posts a record-class documentary opening from 855 screens; 'Whalefall' flops

Variety: Street Fighter, You Can See Everything, Whalefall box office

LOS ANGELES — Paramount and Legendary's video-game adaptation 'Street Fighter' took first place this weekend with an estimated $31 million from 3,575 theaters. That is about 19 percent below the $38.5 million opening of 'Mortal Kombat 2', and the studio had hoped for more. The bigger story was A24's three-hour Elizabeth Holmes documentary 'You Can See Everything', directed by Lance Oppenheim and Nathan Fielder. It opened to an estimated $15 million from only 855 theaters, a per-theater average of about $17,500. Deadline calls that the second-best documentary opening ever. It reportedly cost under $10 million to make. Disney's $60 million 'Whalefall' opened to only about $8 million, well under the $10 million to $12 million that tracking suggested. Critics were hard on 'Street Fighter', which holds roughly 40 percent positive on Rotten Tomatoes. Total weekend grosses are estimated near $107 million, about 58 percent above the same weekend last year. Final figures arrive Monday.

WHY IT MATTERS: A cheap, specialty-release documentary outperformed a studio-backed franchise film on a per-screen basis, which could affect how distributors weigh nonfiction releases and mid-budget thrillers.

Sources: Deadline: Street Fighter $31M, You Can See Everything $15M (Sunday update); Variety: Street Fighter, You Can See Everything, Whalefall box office; TheWrap: Street Fighter tops box office; You Can See Everything tops Whalefall

Netflix replaces content chief Bajaria with Peter Rice after 1,000 layoffs

Shake-up comes days before third-quarter earnings and as the streamer plans a theatrical Narnia release

CNBC: Netflix Chief Content Officer Bela Bajaria is leaving, will be replaced by Peter Rice

LOS GATOS, CALIF. — Netflix said Thursday that Bela Bajaria is leaving as chief content officer after about a decade. She will be replaced by Peter Rice, a former Disney and Fox executive, effective October 26. Rice will run global content, including series, film and live events. The announcement came a day after Netflix cut about 1,000 jobs, roughly 6 percent of its workforce. That is its largest reduction since 2022. TheWrap reports the company's stock is down nearly 40 percent from a year ago. Co-CEO Ted Sarandos told staff the company sees a chance to deliver more 'buzzy' hits in the U.S. and Canada. BMO analyst Brian Pitz said the moves suggest engagement may have softened further in the third quarter. Variety notes that reports that film chief Dan Lin will also exit have not been confirmed. Netflix reports earnings October 20, and it plans a full theatrical release in February for Greta Gerwig's 'Narnia: The Magician's Nephew'.

WHY IT MATTERS: Leadership of the world's largest streamer is changing as it tries to restore engagement, which affects its film slate, its theatrical strategy and speculation about acquisitions.

Sources: CNBC: Netflix Chief Content Officer Bela Bajaria is leaving, will be replaced by Peter Rice; TheWrap: Bajaria out, Peter Rice in; Variety: How Netflix's messy transition will rock Hollywood

Loznitsa's 'Imperium' wins top prize at BFI London Film Festival

Thai family drama '9 Temples To Heaven' takes first-feature award; Jordan-set 'Concrete Land' wins documentary prize

Screen Daily: Imperium leads BFI London Film Festival winners

LONDON — Sergei Loznitsa's 'Imperium' won best film in the Official Competition at the BFI London Film Festival, which wraps up today. The festival's juries gave the first-feature Sutherland award to Sompot Chidgasornpongse's '9 Temples To Heaven'. It follows a man who takes his ailing mother and nine relatives on a temple pilgrimage. Bertil Nilsson's 'Masc' received a special mention in that section. Asmahan Bkerat's 'Concrete Land', about a mixed-race family fighting displacement and hostility in Jordan, took the Grierson award for best documentary. 'Queer Edward II' by Theo Rollason received a special mention in that section. Rahul Roye's 'Aman' won best short film. Voting for the audience awards closes Wednesday, October 21. The awards-season calendar continues with AFI Fest, which opens Thursday in Los Angeles, and Gotham Awards nominations on October 27.

WHY IT MATTERS: London's prizes add momentum for international and first-time filmmakers heading into the late-autumn awards calendar.

Sources: Screen Daily: Imperium leads BFI London Film Festival winners; Hollywood Reporter: Awards Season Calendar

MUSIC: PIANO & CLASSICAL

Chilean Chamber Orchestra bus crash kills American principal violist Penélope Knuth

The New York-born musician had led the viola section for more than three decades; 13 colleagues were hurt

The Strad

VALPARAÍSO — A bus carrying members of the Chamber Orchestra of Chile went off a steep Valparaíso street on the evening of October 10 and fell into a condominium car park. The orchestra was returning from a concert at the Federico Santa María Technical University. Principal violist Penélope Knuth, born in New York and trained at Indiana University and Juilliard, died. She had led the section since 1994 and taught generations of violists at the Pontifical Catholic University of Chile. Chile's culture ministry reported 13 people injured, four of them seriously. Reports put the fall at roughly 15 to 25 metres. The driver was detained and a court extended his detention while prosecutors gathered evidence. The cause has not been established. Officials have raised questions about whether a bus of that size should have used the route.

WHY IT MATTERS: The death of a veteran principal musician from a state orchestra is a major loss for Chile's musical life and for the viola community internationally.

Sources: The Strad; La Tercera (Santiago); Moto Perpetuo

Gramophone Awards 2026: Chamayou and Andsnes take piano prize; Couperin box is Record of the Year

Isabelle Faust named Artist of the Year; one critic calls the overall slate a misjudgment

Slipped Disc

LONDON — Gramophone announced its 2026 awards on October 9. Bertrand Chamayou and Leif Ove Andsnes won the Piano category for their two-disc Schubert four-hands recording, which the magazine's reviewer called an instant classic. Isabelle Faust was named Artist of the Year, with her recording of the Ligeti Violin Concerto cited. Mezzo-soprano Adèle Charvet and pianist Florian Caroubi won the Song award for 'Belle époque!' on Alpha. Slipped Disc reports that the top prize, Recording of the Year, went to a ten-disc set of Louis Couperin's complete works. That site's editor, Norman Lebrecht, criticised the choice as marginal, which is his view and not a consensus. The shortlist had also included Yunchan Lim's Bach Goldberg Variations on Decca and Yuja Wang's Shostakovich piano concertos with the Boston Symphony on DG.

WHY IT MATTERS: The awards are among the most closely watched in recorded classical music and shape sales and critical reputations for pianists and labels.

Sources: Presto Music / Gramophone Awards 2026 winners; Gramophone Awards 2026 shortlist; Slipped Disc

Memphis Symphony stages Verdi's Rigoletto with Opera Memphis on October 24

The 75th-anniversary season continues after a Vaughan Williams program at the Scheidt Center

Wikipedia

MEMPHIS — The Memphis Symphony Orchestra will perform Verdi's Rigoletto in concert on Saturday, October 24, at 7:30 p.m. at the Cannon Center for the Performing Arts. Music Director Robert Moody conducts the collaboration with Opera Memphis. The orchestra's season opened in September and marks its 75th year. The most recent program, October 10 and 11 at the University of Memphis's Scheidt Family Performing Arts Center, paired Vaughan Williams's Dona Nobis Pacem with The Lark Ascending, with concertmaster Barrie Cooper as soloist. Next is Orchestra Unplugged: The Planets on October 30 at the Halloran Centre. Later in the season: a world premiere of a new Requiem about U.S. forces in the Pacific from 1942 to 1975, a tribute to naval aviator Jesse L. Brown, and a Grieg Piano Concerto program in May.

WHY IT MATTERS: The opera collaboration and the 75th-season programming are the Memphis Symphony's main fall draws, and the local piano-concerto dates come later in the season.

Sources: Memphis Symphony Orchestra – Rigoletto in Concert; WKNO-FM – MSO 75th season Classic Accents; WKNO-FM – Robert Moody previews the 75th season

Gramophone critics back Schiff's Brahms, Bavouzet's Beethoven context and Tharaud's Mémoire

Piano discs feature prominently in the magazine's October and Awards-issue Editor's Choices

Wikipedia

LONDON — Gramophone's October Editor's Choices include András Schiff's recording of Brahms's late Klavierstücke. The reviewer praises its range of colour between registers and the transparency of texture, which fits Rubinstein's description of the pieces as chamber music for solo pianist. The Awards issue adds Jean-Efflam Bavouzet's The Beethoven Connection, Vol. 2. The reviewer says the idea is a good one and would buy it for the Hummel sonata alone. It also adds Alexandre Tharaud's Mémoire, which the critic calls an unpretentious album that could slip under the radar. The Rautio Piano Trio's period-instrument Beethoven Op. 70 trios are also picked, for transparency and conversational intimacy. The issue's lead recording is Simon Rattle's live Mahler Second with the Bavarian Radio forces.

WHY IT MATTERS: Magazine Editor's Choices guide buyers and streamers, and this month's picks favour thoughtful, repertoire-driven piano albums over display.

Sources: Presto Music – Gramophone Editor's Choices, Awards Issue 2026; Presto Music – Gramophone Editor's Choices, October 2026; Gramophone – Editor's Choice: Awards issue 2026

SPORTS

Wikipedia

Tasoev wins third judo world title as Japan retakes mixed team crown

Russian heavyweight beats Azerbaijan's Kokauri in Baku; Abu Dhabi Grand Slam is next on the IJF calendar

BAKU — Inal Tasoev of Russia won his third world heavyweight (+100 kg) title at the World Judo Championships in Baku on October 10. He beat Azerbaijan's Ushangi Kokauri with an ouchi-gari counter, JudoInside reported. The win stretched Tasoev's record against Kokauri to 8-0. The 28-year-old also won in 2023 and 2025. Inside The Games reported that his only bout without an ippon was a one-yuko quarterfinal win over double Olympic champion Lukas Krpalek. Krpalek and Azerbaijan's Kanan Nasibov took bronze. South Korea's Lee Hyeon-ji won the women's +78 kg title. On the final day Uzbekistan eliminated defending mixed team champion Georgia, then lost 4-3 to Russia in the semifinal. Japan reclaimed the mixed team title. The IJF World Tour moves next to the Abu Dhabi Grand Slam, October 29-31, which lists 293 judoka from 45 countries.

WHY IT MATTERS: The Worlds set the 2026 world rankings and the pecking order for the next Olympic cycle, and Tasoev's run puts him level with the heavyweight record of three titles.

Sources: JudoInside: Tasoev crushes Azerbaijan's heavyweight dream; Inside The Games: Baku 2026, Tasoev wins in dominant style; JudoInside: Uzbekistan stun defending champions as Russia and Japan reach team final

JIU-JITSU & JUDO

IBJJF heavyweight world champion Rider Zuchi banned three years for steroids

USADA-run test at May Worlds found anabolic agents; title and results back to August 2024 erased

BJJ Eastern Europe: Rider Zuchi suspended 3 years after positive PED test

Rider Samelo do Amaral, known as Rider Zuchi, accepted a three-year ineligibility period after an in-competition test at the IBJJF World Championship on May 31. The sample showed drostanolone and a metabolite of nandrolone or related steroids, according to BJJEE and FloGrappling's Portuguese report on the USADA announcement. The IBJJF is not a World Anti-Doping Code signatory, but it contracted USADA to run testing at the event. Zuchi admitted the violation within 20 days, which cut the otherwise four-year ban by one year. The ban began July 1, 2026 and runs to July 2029. He lost his 2026 heavyweight gold and every result since August 23, 2024. The IBJJF has reshuffled the podium and promoted the runner-up from the final. BJJEE noted that testing covers only part of the field.

WHY IT MATTERS: It is one of the biggest doping cases in gi jiu-jitsu and renews debate over how widely elite BJJ events should test.

Sources: BJJ Eastern Europe: Rider Zuchi suspended 3 years after positive PED test; FloGrappling: Rider Zuchi é pego no anti-doping e fica suspenso por 3 anos; Jits Magazine: Rider Zuchi stripped of IBJJF world title and suspended for 3 years

Jaworski and Galvão take double gold at IBJJF No-Gi Pans

Secaucus event drew more than 2,300 athletes; The Crown follows November 8 in Long Beach

IBJJF: 2026 Pan No-Gi Championship results breakdown

SECAUCUS, N.J. — At the IBJJF Pan No-Gi Championship, held October 2-4 at the Meadowlands Exposition Center, Pawel Jaworski of Academia Gorila and Sarah Galvão of Atos each won two black-belt golds. The IBJJF's recap said Jaworski, ranked No. 1 in men's no-gi, won the open class by referee decision over heavyweight champion Wallisson Oliveira. Alexandre 'Lele' Manara won ultra-heavy with a heel hook over Sean Goolsby. Natã Tenca won super-heavy in a closeout with Andre Galvão, and Pierre-Olivier Leclerc took lightweight. In the women's black-belt divisions, Maia Matalon won heavy by arm-triangle and Sabrina Gondim took featherweight. Galvão, 20, had lost the ADCC -65 kg final to Ana Carolina Vieira in double overtime in September. Next up are the IBJJF European No-Gi from October 28, and The Crown on November 8, streaming on FloGrappling.

WHY IT MATTERS: Pans results feed the no-gi rankings, and heel hooks and leg locks again decided many of the big finals.

Sources: IBJJF: 2026 Pan No-Gi Championship results breakdown; IBJJF: Pan No-Gi 2026 official results; BJJ Heroes: 2026 IBJJF Pan American No-Gi Championship Results

MMA

Malott knocks out Buckley with knee as Canada finishes strong in Edmonton

Home fighters Mike Malott and Jasmine Jasudavicius closed UFC Fight Night with a knockout and a ranked upset

UFC.com – Main Card Results, UFC Edmonton

EDMONTON — Welterweight Mike Malott ended the UFC's Edmonton card on Saturday with a second-round knee knockout of Joaquin Buckley at 2:32 of a scheduled five-rounder. The knee landed flush on Buckley's chin and sent his mouthpiece flying. It was Malott's second straight main-event finish and fifth consecutive win in Canada, according to the UFC. In the co-main event, local flyweight Jasmine Jasudavicius beat Erin Blanchfield, a ranked title contender, by unanimous decision, with all three judges scoring it 29-28. Apart from that decision, all 12 other bouts on the 13-fight card ended by knockout, stoppage or submission, including Cristian Perez's 27-second KO of Kyle Nelson in his UFC debut. UFC president Dana White said the results helped both Canadians. The UFC has announced a return to Toronto in January, and UFC 333 in Abu Dhabi follows on October 24.

WHY IT MATTERS: A top-15 welterweight knockout and an upset over a flyweight contender reshape two divisions and give the UFC two Canadian draws ahead of its Toronto return.

Sources: UFC.com – Main Card Results, UFC Edmonton; Tapology – UFC Fight Night: Buckley vs. Malott; MMA Mania – Biggest winners, loser from UFC Edmonton

White gives vague answer on release of unbeaten bantamweight Farid Basharat

The UFC chief says there is 'definitely a reason' a 16-0 fighter was not re-signed; the fighter has offered his own account

Cageside Press – Dana White addresses Basharat release

EDMONTON — Dana White was asked after Saturday's card why the UFC did not re-sign Farid Basharat, a 29-year-old bantamweight who is 16-0 overall and 7-0 in the promotion. White named no specific cause. He said fighters are sometimes let go when they are hard to deal with, when matchmakers do not want to work with them, or when they turn down fights. He then said an unbeaten fighter with seven UFC wins who is not re-signed has a reason. Basharat, who had reached No. 8 in the media bantamweight rankings, said in a recent statement that the promotion is not what it once was. Cageside Press reads that as a nod to his decision-heavy record. Six of his seven UFC wins came by decision, according to NY Fights. White's remarks did not establish that Basharat refused any bout. Basharat is now a free agent.

WHY IT MATTERS: The case reopens the argument over how much finishing ability and matchmaking relationships, rather than record and ranking, decide who stays on the UFC roster.

Sources: Cageside Press – Dana White addresses Basharat release; Bloody Elbow – White offers vague response on Basharat; MMA Mania – Dana White on controversial UFC release

Bishop outpoints Carmouche for PFL flyweight title; Khizriev decision draws fire

Chicago card produced a women's title change and a disputed split decision for an unbeaten featherweight

Fightnews.com – Complete PFL Chicago results

CHICAGO — Jena Bishop beat Liz Carmouche by unanimous decision, 48-47 on all three scorecards, to win the PFL women's flyweight world championship on Friday at Wintrust Arena. Bishop was ranked No. 4 going in. Bleacher Report's live blog says she was hurt early, while Carmouche fended off her submission attempts. In the co-main event, featherweight Timur Khizriev improved to 19-0 with a split decision over Gabriel Braga, 29-28 twice and 28-29 once. Bleacher Report called the result dubious, saying Khizriev was badly hurt in the first two rounds and landed none of his takedown attempts. Eliezer Kubanza knocked out Trey Waters in 1:36 of the first round and then called out welterweight champion Thad Jean, South Africa's IOL reported. Bantamweight Sarvarjon Khamidov also knocked out Rafael do Nascimento in the first round.

WHY IT MATTERS: A new women's flyweight champion and a contested decision for one of the PFL's top unbeaten featherweights both feed into the promotion's title pictures.

Sources: Fightnews.com – Complete PFL Chicago results; Bleacher Report – PFL Chicago 2 live updates and results; IOL – Kubanza calls out PFL champion Thad Jean

TRAVEL

The National: Riyadh airport reopens, which airlines are still cancelling

Riyadh airport reopens, but many airlines keep Saudi flights suspended

King Khalid International resumes after Houthi strikes; US advisory for Saudi Arabia stands at Level 3

RIYADH — Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport reopened Sunday after a closure that began with a Houthi missile strike on October 10. Saudi authorities and wire reports put the death toll from that strike at 13, with about 309 injured. Many carriers have not yet returned. Etihad has cancelled Abu Dhabi-Riyadh service through Monday. Air France is out through October 24, Lufthansa through November 18, and Cathay Pacific through January 31, 2027. British Airways plans a limited return on November 3. The State Department set Saudi Arabia at Level 3, Reconsider Travel, on October 12, with a Do Not Travel zone near the Yemen border. The US Mission has told Americans to use extreme caution at Saudi airports. It also restricts US government employees from using them without special authorization. The Houthis have said they will keep targeting Saudi infrastructure.

WHY IT MATTERS: Riyadh is a major Gulf aviation hub, and its reduced service plus a Level 3 US advisory affect business and pilgrimage travel and connections through the region.

Sources: The National: Riyadh airport reopens, which airlines are still cancelling; US Embassy Saudi Arabia: Security Alert, October 14, 2026; OSAC: Travel Advisory, Saudi Arabia, Level 3 (from travel.state.gov)

TRAVEL NEWS

State Department to add wrongful-detention warning to China travel advisory

Overall Level 2 rating reportedly unchanged; new 'D' risk indicator replaces 'O'

Semafor: State Department warns travelers to China they risk wrongful detention

WASHINGTON — The State Department is preparing to add a wrongful-detention risk indicator, marked 'D', to its travel advisory for mainland China, according to a plan reviewed by Semafor and published October 16. The overall advisory would stay at Level 2, Exercise Increased Caution. The 'D' would replace the 'O' indicator, which covers other risks. A department spokesman told Semafor that Americans face a serious risk of wrongful detention in China. The spokesman said the overall level reflects a broader safety assessment. The move follows an early-September update that strengthened warnings on wrongful detention, arbitrary enforcement of local laws and exit bans. Semafor reported that a bipartisan group of senators introduced a resolution last month urging the change, citing two detained US citizens. The report describes a plan, and the department has not published the revised advisory.

WHY IT MATTERS: Travelers and companies sending staff to China will see an explicit official warning, even though the overall rating is unchanged.

Sources: Semafor: State Department warns travelers to China they risk wrongful detention

DIVE DESTINATIONS

Hammerhead and whale shark season in the Pacific runs through November

El Niño muddied Galápagos diving earlier this year; Cocos is at peak, and Socorro's mantas return next month

Aggressor Adventures: Hammerhead shark diving liveaboards

The cool-season window for big animals in the eastern Pacific is still open but closing. At Darwin and Wolf in the Galápagos, reachable only by liveaboard, whale sharks are typically seen from June to November and hammerheads school year-round. A diver's review that cites operator updates says El Niño-warmed water brought fewer sharks in May and June, with whale sharks and hammerheads back from mid-July and August. Expect 16-23C water, 15-20 m visibility and advanced-level current diving. Cocos Island, 550 km off Costa Rica, peaks from June to November. Aggressor boats leave Puntarenas on a roughly 36-hour crossing, with dives of 55-110 feet. Socorro's liveaboard season opens in November, from San José del Cabo. Memphis has only domestic nonstops, so every route needs a connection; Southwest has advertised Memphis-Los Cabos fares.

WHY IT MATTERS: Whale shark season in the Galápagos and Cocos ends in November, and the best boats book up months ahead.

Sources: Aggressor Adventures: Hammerhead shark diving liveaboards; This Is Luxury Travel: Galapagos Diving Guide (El Niño 2026-27); Liveaboard.com: Cocos Island season guide

Cozumel closes four reefs through November as drift diving continues elsewhere

Mexico's park agency is resting San Francisco and Santa Rosa; the island's other sites remain open

Reportur: Cozumel frenan por un mes el turismo en arrecifes

COZUMEL — Mexico's national protected-areas commission, CONANP, has closed four sites in the Cozumel Reefs National Park to tourism from October 1 to November 30: San Francisco, San Francisco Bajo, Santa Rosa and the Santa Rosa Wall. The sites are four of the park's 34 reefs. The rotating-closure program began in 2019, after stony coral tissue loss disease appeared in 2018 and bleaching followed. CONANP's local director says recovery cannot be formally measured, but the agency has seen more fish and healthier coral. Dive shops report that the rest of the island is open, with nearly all diving done as drifts along the reef wall and visibility above 100 feet. It suits divers of all levels. From Memphis there are no nonstops to Cancun; connections run through Atlanta, Dallas, Miami and Houston. American lists November fares from about $506.

WHY IT MATTERS: Cozumel is the easiest warm-water reef trip from Memphis, and its closures show how Caribbean parks are managing coral disease.

Sources: Heraldo de México (Quintana Roo): Cierran cuatro arrecifes de Cozumel; Reportur: Cozumel frenan por un mes el turismo en arrecifes; Blue Note Scuba: Cozumel diving guide, October 2026

OFF THE BEATEN PATH

Fast train now reaches Khiva, opening Uzbekistan's Silk Road loop

A Tashkent–Khiva high-speed service launched in May and cut the journey roughly in half; Americans can enter visa-free

Euronews - New high-speed rail link Tashkent-Khiva

KHIVA, UZBEKISTAN — Khiva, the walled desert city of Itchan Kala, used to be the hardest stop on Uzbekistan's Silk Road circuit. A Hyundai-built high-speed train, the Jaloliddin Manguberdi, began running from Tashkent on 1 May. It cuts the trip from about 14 hours to roughly seven and a half. Samarkand and Bukhara were already linked by the Afrosiyob train. One travel guide says the new service has limited departures and sells out quickly. Forbes reported that U.S. citizens can enter visa-free for 30 days in 2026. The State Department lists Uzbekistan at Level 1, normal precautions, and warns that medical care is below U.S. standards. Operators run Silk Road departures from late March into late November. From Memphis there is no nonstop service, so travelers should expect at least one connection to reach Tashkent.

WHY IT MATTERS: A once-remote UNESCO city is now an easy rail leg on a safe, inexpensive route that few Americans have taken.

Sources: U.S. State Department - Uzbekistan Travel Advisory; Euronews - New high-speed rail link Tashkent-Khiva; Forbes - Uzbekistan now visa-free for U.S. travelers

Greece's northern Sporades offer a quiet October sailing and ferry circuit

Skiathos, Skopelos and Alonissos sit under a Level 1 advisory, with ferry service thinning as the season closes

Skopelosweb - Ferry routes and timetables 2026

SKOPELOS, GREECE — The Northern Sporades are a short hop from the Greek mainland but draw far smaller crowds than Santorini or Mykonos. A charter-company guide describes October as calm and quiet, with Skopelos's coast, Alonissos's coves and Skiathos's beaches free of the summer rush. Another guide says the Greek island season runs April to October and stays pleasant into autumn. The State Department rates Greece Level 1, with petty crime and short-notice demonstrations that can disrupt transport as the main cautions. Skiathos has the only airport, with domestic flights from Athens. Skopelos and Alonissos are reached by ferry from Skiathos or from Volos. One high-speed catamaran was scheduled to run only until 4 October, so travelers should confirm timetables. Memphis has no nonstop to Greece; expect a U.S. or European connection to Athens.

WHY IT MATTERS: It is a low-risk, lightly visited sailing and island-hopping option that is still workable through October.

Sources: U.S. State Department - Greece Travel Advisory; Skopelosweb - Ferry routes and timetables 2026; Greeka - How to get to Skiathos

REFLECTIONS

DAILY SCRIPTURE

Clothed in daily kindness

Colossians 3:12-17 · World English Bible

[12] *Put on therefore, as God's chosen ones, holy and beloved, a heart of compassion, kindness, lowliness, humility, and perseverance;* [13] *bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, if any man has a complaint against any; even as Christ forgave you, so you also do.* [14] *Above all these things, walk in love, which is the bond of perfection.* [15] *And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to which also you were called in one body; and be thankful.* [16] *Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly; in all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another with psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your heart to the Lord.* [17] *Whatever you do, in word or in deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father, through him.*

This passage treats character like a wardrobe chosen each morning: patience, humility, forgiveness, and kindness put on deliberately rather than waiting for a mood to arrive. It names love as the thing that holds the rest together, which is a useful reminder that virtues work best in company. Gratitude runs through it too, as a steady habit more than a feeling. On a Sunday, it invites us to carry that ordinary, practiced goodness into the week ahead, in what we say and in how we do our work.

DAILY STOIC

Epictetus

Enchiridion (Manual), Section 34

> *When you get an external impression of some pleasure, guard yourself, as with impressions in general, against being carried away by it; nay, let the matter wait upon your leisure, and give yourself a little delay. Next think of the two periods of time, first, that in which you will enjoy your pleasure, and second, that in which, after the enjoyment is over, you will later repent and revile your own self; and set over against these two periods of time how much joy and self-satisfaction you will get if you refrain. However, if you feel that a suitable occasion has arisen to do the deed, be careful not to allow its enticement, and sweetness, and attractiveness to overcome you; but set over against all this the thought, how much better is the consciousness of having won a victory over it.*

W. A. Oldfather, 1928

Epictetus was born a slave, gained his freedom, and taught philosophy in Nicopolis in Greece, where his student Arrian wrote down his lectures. Arrian also drew the short Enchiridion, or 'handbook', from those teachings, and it survived through centuries of copying in the Greek-speaking world.

Most of us don't lose our footing to big temptations. We lose it to small ones that arrive looking harmless: a second helping, a late-night scroll, a sharp reply we're eager to send. Epictetus doesn't tell us to despise pleasure. He asks us to stall it a little and picture the version of ourselves who comes afterward. That later self is usually the one who pays for the bargain. The pause is rarely a loss. It gives you room to choose, and there is a quiet satisfaction in having chosen.

PRACTICE: The next time you feel a strong pull toward something you may regret, such as a snack, a purchase, a message or a bit of gossip, wait ten minutes before acting. During that time, picture how you will feel an hour later if you give in, and how you will feel if you hold off. Then decide.

THE COMMONPLACE BOOK · HISTORY

The Friday That Happened Twice in Sitka

When the US took over Alaska on October 18, 1867, the town's calendar was reset. Residents got two Fridays in a row.

The treaty was signed in a hurry. On the evening of March 29, 1867, Russia's minister, Eduard de Stoeckl, brought Secretary of State William Seward word that St. Petersburg had approved the sale. Stoeckl offered to start work the next day. Seward said they should do it that night. The two men signed at about 4 a.m. on March 30. The price was $7.2 million in gold, about two cents an acre.

The handover came on Friday, October 18, at Sitka, on a gray afternoon at the governor's residence on Castle Hill. Russian and American troops lined up, and cannon fired from ships in the harbor. Then the Russian flag jammed on its pole. According to one eyewitness account, two soldiers climbed up and failed before a third brought it down. Captain Aleksei Peshchurov then told General Lovell Rousseau that he transferred the territory to the United States.

The calendar changed too. Russia still used the Julian calendar, which ran 12 days behind the Gregorian one. Alaska had also counted its days on the Asian side of the International Date Line, because its settlers had come from Siberia. Under American rule it moved to the other side. The net effect was that Friday, October 6 (Julian) was followed by another Friday, October 18. Alaskans lost 11 days, not 12.

Payment was slower. Congress did not appropriate the money until July 1868, and the Treasury issued the draft on August 1. A House inquiry that winter looked into where some of the money had gone, since Stoeckl had paid lobbyists. It reached no firm conclusion.

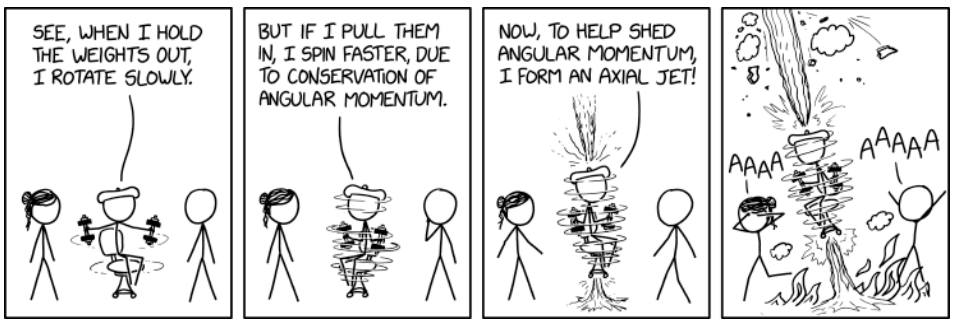
REMEMBER: Alaska changed hands on a Friday that followed another Friday, because the territory switched calendars and crossed the International Date Line on the same afternoon.

READ NEXT: Milton O. Gustafson, "Seward's Bargain: The Alaska Purchase from Russia" (Prologue, Winter 1994)

THE FUNNIES

xkcd · RANDALL MUNROE

Momentum Demonstration



"I'm doing really well on the Hertzsprung-Russell academic diagram, which has spectral class on one axis and Rate My Professors rating on the other."

Poorly Drawn Lines · REZA FARAZMAND

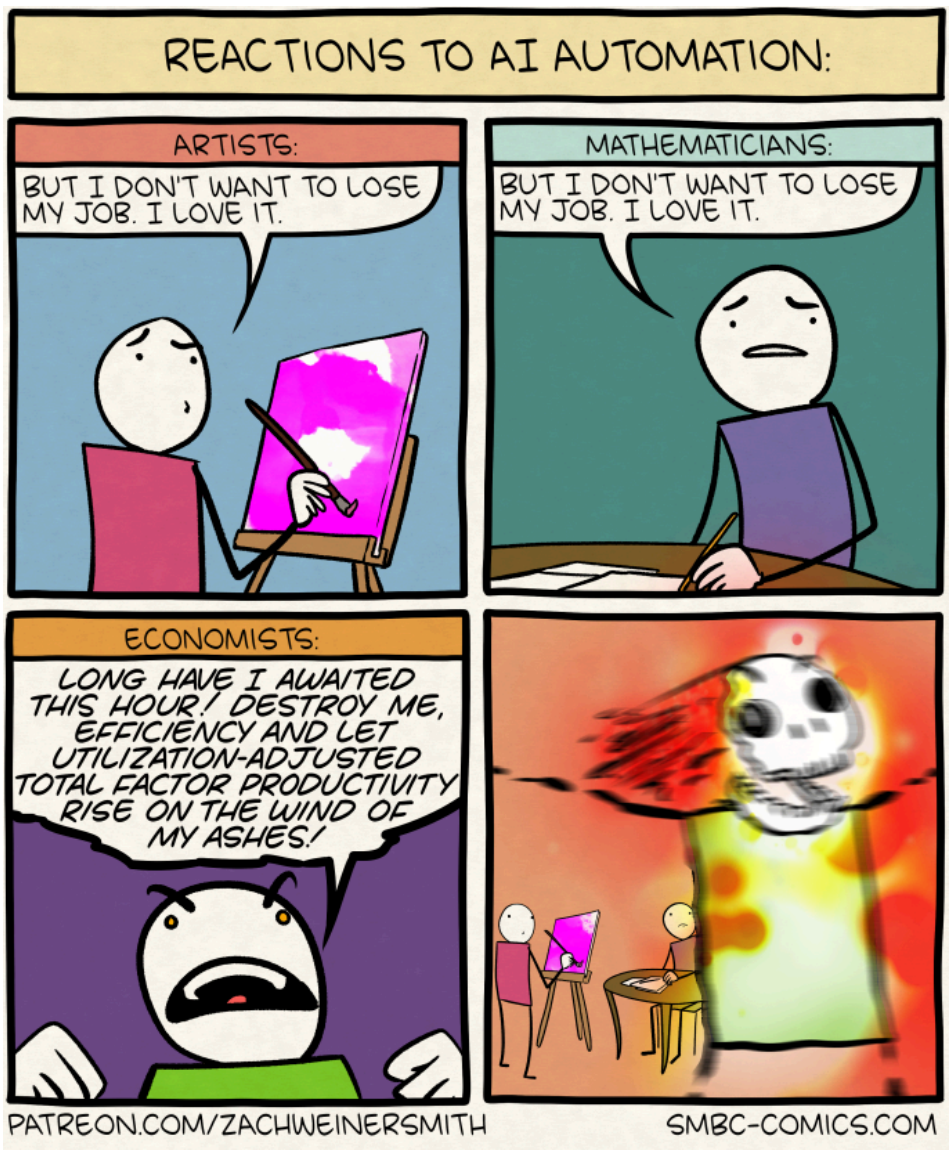
See You

Existential Comics · COREY MOHLER

Nietzsche Finds a Genie

Saturday Morning Breakfast Cereal · ZACH WEINERSMITH

Reactions



Meanwhile the Engineers are just lighting themselves on fire to see what happens.